



Transition to Adulthood Tool Kit

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About this Tool Kit

This tool kit outlines important considerations in planning for adulthood. It is primarily designed for transition-aged autistic people (aged 12 to 25 years old) and their parents/caregivers.

Effective transition planning bridges the gap between school and adult life. It should address key areas such as education, employment, independent living, community engagement, healthcare, self-advocacy and legal and financial planning. By considering these areas early, individuals with autism, no matter their level of diagnosis, can build the skills, confidence and support needed to lead fulfilling adult lives.

“The breadth of this tool kit mirrors the reality of autism in adulthood, whereby success is not defined by one domain but by a coordinated network of supports.”

— Dr. Muhsinah L. Morris, mother of autistic son, Autism Speaks Community Advisory Council member and Metaversity Director and Professor at Morehouse College.

NOTE: Throughout this Tool Kit, we primarily speak directly to transition-aged autistic individuals and their parents or caregivers. At times, we also refer to autistic people in the third person. In doing so, we use both identity-first language (for example, “autistic person”) and person-first language (for example, “person with autism”) to honor the varied preferences within the autistic community. Whenever we share personal stories, we always defer to the individual’s own language preference.

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Introduction

Becoming an adult is a process, often referred to as the **transition to adulthood**. It involves a series of developmental tasks and milestones related to:

- Postsecondary education or training
- Employment and vocational skills
- Independent or supported living
- Community participation
- Adult healthcare and wellness
- Becoming a legal adult at age 18

Studies consistently show that early transition planning while in school makes a big difference in autistic people's lives. Specifically, a good **transition plan** leads to reduced anxiety, and an increased chance of finding a job, going to college or other postsecondary training, and living a healthier and more independent adult life.

Healthcare professionals and other autism service providers recommend all those with autism start transition planning as soon as 12 years old. Those with an Individualized Education Program (IEP) are federally required to have a formal transition plan in place no later than age 16, though some states mandate one be in place as young as 14.

For a transition plan to be most effective, the autistic individual must be actively involved in it, as best as they can be. It should be developed based on their strengths, needs, preferences and aspirations. That will best help you plan for future supports and work on developing necessary skills, including self-advocacy, to lead a productive, fulfilling adult life.

While this tool kit suggests a transition planning timeline, keep in mind, it is flexible. You should expect that your goals may change, and that you will adjust the plan over time to support your goals.

For parents and caregivers: we all want our children to be happy and to live fulfilling lives. But remember, what constitutes happiness or fulfillment for your child is specific to them. What may be appropriate or desired employment, housing, postsecondary education, or community involvement options for someone else, may not be the right fit for them, and vice versa.

The goal of this Tool Kit is to provide you with suggestions and options to consider as you set out on this journey toward finding your or your loved one's own unique path to adulthood. That path may not be linear, and it may not involve every topic covered here. Our hope, though, is that you use this Tool Kit as a guide and learning resource – something you can return to, reflect on, and apply in ways that best support your individual goals and growth.

Foundational Skills

Self-advocacy

What is self-advocacy

Self-advocacy is widely recognized as one of the most important components of transition planning for autistic individuals. It involves communicating your needs, knowing your rights and responsibilities and using the resources and supports to pursue your goals. There's no single "right way" to self-advocate. Importantly, it will look different for everyone. Key skills include:

- Identifying emotions and needs, especially what brings you joy and happiness
- Reducing internalized shame around your emotions and needs
- Finding and using tools/accommodations that help you
- Communicating your needs using your preferred method
- Making decisions and setting goals for yourself and/or with supports

For an autistic person with lower support needs, for example, it could mean requesting sensory accommodations at work and using noise-canceling headphones.

For an autistic person with higher support needs or profound autism, it could look like learning to use an Augmentative and Alternative Communication (AAC) device to communicate to their aide their lunch choice in a cafeteria.

How to build self-advocacy skills

- Make a list of your strengths, your likes, what makes you happy and what matters to you most.
- Acknowledge any challenges you have and consider what you need to manage them.
- Accept that it is ok to ask for help. Everyone, no matter who they are, needs help at some point in life.
- Identify your emotions. Does anything make you especially happy? Mad? Anxious? It is important to recognize and remember these so you can cope with them in the future.
- Set some goals for your future. Is there a job you would like to have? Is there something you want to learn? Is there an interest you want to pursue?
- Build a support network. Who can help you with all of the above, or help in general? Who can you call or text even when you do not need help, just to say hello and check-in?
- Practice communicating in the manner that best works for you. If talking is difficult, try writing or using assisted technology. Whatever helps you communicate comfortably is a great choice.
- Know that you are never too old to learn, change or improve.
- Remember there is only one you. Be yourself. You deserve to live authentically and joyfully.

Learn more: Autism Speaks [Roadmap to Self-Empowerment](#)

How to teach your loved one self-advocacy skills

For most of your loved one's life, you have probably been the one advocating for them. Stepping aside from advocating for them can be hard for any caregiver. It may even be unrealistic if you care for someone with higher support needs. A caregiver of a nonverbal adult with profound autism will most likely always be involved in their advocacy in some way.

Learn more: [Important considerations in transition planning](#)

But every autistic individual deserves the opportunity to learn self-advocacy skills. Perhaps for one child it will look like teaching them how to make a simple recipe. For another, it may be teaching them how to use a choice board to decide on clothes for certain weather or certain settings.

One of the best ways to help your autistic loved one learn self-advocacy skills is by exploring and supporting their interests and skills. This will help them build their communication skills and encourage them to take an active role in decision-making as an adult.

Another way you can encourage self-advocacy is by including your loved one in all your advocacy efforts. Show them in words and actions that you are proud of them as they are, in both private and public.

Learn more: *Autism Speaks* [Advocacy Tool Kit](#)

Rights of people with disabilities

Laws protecting disabled citizens

You need to be aware of laws that protect people with disabilities in the United States. Here's a summary of the most important ones:

Americans with Disabilities Act (ADA) (1990)

The ADA is a civil rights law prohibiting discrimination based on disability in "employment, state

and local government, public accommodations, commercial facilities, transportation, and telecommunications." Autism meets the ADA definition of disability since it can significantly impact major life activities, such as communication, social interaction, and learning.

Title I requires employers with 15 or more employees to provide disabled people an equal opportunity to benefit from the full range of employment-related opportunities available to others. It prohibits discrimination in recruitment, hiring, promotions, training, pay, social activities and other privileges of employment. It restricts questions that can be asked about an applicant's disability before a job offer is made, and it requires that employers make reasonable accommodation to the known physical or mental limitations of otherwise qualified individuals with disabilities, unless it results in undue hardship.

Title II of the ADA applies to all public schools from preschool through postsecondary institutions. They cannot discriminate against students with disabilities and must provide reasonable modifications to policies, practices, and procedures. Most private non-religious schools are covered under Title III of the ADA, which prohibits discrimination based on disability. The ADA also extends to extra-curricular activities, athletics, and off-campus activities.

Individuals with Disabilities Education Act (IDEA)

The Individuals with Disabilities Education Act (IDEA) requires public schools to provide all eligible children with disabilities a free appropriate public education (FAPE) in the least restrictive environment (LRE) appropriate to their individual needs. The specific special education and related services must be tailored to each student and delivered through an Individualized Education Program (IEP). Each student's IEP must be developed by a team of knowledgeable persons and must be at least reviewed annually.

If a public school district places a student with an IEP in a private school, the private school

must adhere to the IEP and provide the services outlined within it. In these cases, the public school district remains responsible for ensuring the IEP is implemented.

Section 504 of the Rehabilitation Act of 1973

Section 504 states that “no qualified individual with a disability in the United States shall be excluded from, denied the benefits of, or be subjected to discrimination under” any program or activity that either receives federal funding. It ensures that individuals with disabilities have equal access to opportunities and benefits, including in education, employment and healthcare.

This includes public schools and universities. But even private schools that do not receive federal funds are still bound by Section 504. All are required to provide a free appropriate public education (FAPE) through reasonable accommodations and modifications. Specific services and supports can be delivered through a 504 plan. But even without such a formal plan, students with disabilities are still protected from discrimination under Section 504.

Section 504 also plays a crucial role in ensuring equal opportunities for individuals with disabilities in workplaces. It generally applies to all employers, agencies, businesses, organizations and programs that receive any federal funding (example: grants or loans). It protects both job applicants and employees with disabilities, and those who are applicants, participants and/or beneficiaries of the covered entities’ federally funded programs.

Fair Housing Act (FHA)

The Fair Housing Act prohibits housing discrimination on the basis of race, color, religion, sex, disability, familial status, and national origin. Its coverage includes private housing, federally funded housing, and state and local government housing.

FHA requires owners of housing facilities to make reasonable policy exceptions to give people with disabilities access to equal housing

opportunities. For example, a landlord with a “no pets” policy may be required to grant an exception to this rule for a disabled person with an emotional support animal. It also requires landlords to allow tenants with disabilities to make reasonable access-related modifications to their private living space, as well as to common use spaces.

Disclosure

Self-advocacy may involve disclosing your autism diagnosis. That decision is personal and depends on the individual, the situation and its potential impact.

Pros to disclosing: It can enable you to be your authentic self, increase autism understanding, help you receive support from others, and access necessary accommodations.

Cons to disclosing: It can lead to judgment, unfair treatment and/or misunderstanding if others are unaware of or misinformed about autism.

Sometimes, you may have to disclose an autism diagnosis to access legally entitled protections available to those with disabilities. If you are a college student, for example, you may need extra time on exams. To receive this common accommodation, available by Section 504 of the American Disabilities Act, you will need to share your diagnosis with your college’s Office for Students with Disabilities (or similarly named department).

Learn more: [Postsecondary Education](#)

Rest assured, you have a legal right to privacy and confidentiality when disclosing your diagnosis in education, employment and medical settings. For instance, if you disclose to your employer that you have autism, your employer must treat that as confidential information. Your coworkers do not have a right to know and your employer legally cannot tell them, unless you grant them permission.

Learn more: [Employment](#)

Sometimes less is more when it comes to disclosure. You only have to share as much information as you feel comfortable, and that will help you receive support. For instance, if you or your loved one are in a crowded store and experiencing physical symptoms of anxiety, you can simply say to a store clerk: “The noise is overwhelming. Is there a quiet area I can use to calm down?” That is a clear and simple request that does not require further explanation for your needs to be met.

Accommodations

Your disability is typically protected by laws that outline that your needs be met by reasonable accommodations. It is important to understand that accommodations are not privileges, but rights afforded to you by the law.

Specifically, accommodations allow you to access everyday life the same as those without disabilities. Often they are simple modifications, like being allowed to wear sunglasses in a brightly lit work environment or working in a quiet space. In fact, they can be beneficial to all employees. So while it is understandable you may feel self-conscious about using an accommodation, you are actually increasing autism acceptance and helping create welcoming work environments for all people.

If you or your loved one has an IEP or 504 plan, then you already are aware of common accommodations to help you through high school. Therapists, school guidance counselors and service providers, like vocational rehabilitation specialists (VR), can help you

identify your potential needs in adulthood and which accommodations could work best for you.

Daily living skills

Fundamental skills

Mastering self-care skills, such as bathing, dressing, cleaning and cooking, is an important predictor of positive outcomes in adulthood.

[Researchers found](#) these skills prove more important than language, intellectual ability or level of autism when it comes to maintaining employment and achieving life satisfaction. So while some autistic people may always need support with even basic living skills, every autistic person can benefit from learning daily living skills.

Of course, learning will look different for everyone. For instance, if you or your loved one have trouble keeping details straight or with the orders of daily living tasks, visual reminders or checklists could be helpful. These may look like:

- A sign on the dishwasher that says “Dirty” or “Clean”.
- Labeling bedroom drawers for different clothing.
- Having a visual schedule of the order of skincare products to use.
- Having a checklist to sort the laundry, start the washer and start the dryer.
- Putting a note on the door with a reminder to grab lunch, backpack and keys.

How to help your loved one achieve independence

from Autism Speaks Autism Response Team (ART)

Work on Self-Care Skills

Brushing teeth, combing hair and other activities of daily living (ADLs) are important life skills. Emphasizing their importance in the transition years will help ensure they become habit. Put together a daily schedule with them and include these in there so they can see when and how long they take. This will make it more likely for them to consider them in their daily routine in the future. See more on **Hygiene** under the [Health](#) section.

Work on Household Chores

Having everyone in the household take on chores teaches responsibility and community. If you think your loved one may have trouble understanding how to complete a chore, break down the chore into smaller steps, use a visual chart and model the chore for them. Try using [MyJobChart](#) or similar tool to help complete tasks and manage time.

Practice Money Skills

Learning how to use money is a very important skill that will help your loved one maintain their well-being and participate in the community. All autistic people can learn basic money skills. At school, consider adding money skills to their IEP. When shopping, point out prices to your loved one and have them hand over the money to the cashier. Consider giving them an allowance for household chores and help them open a bank account.

Encourage Leisure Activities

Being able to engage in independent leisure and recreation is something that will serve your loved one throughout their life. Many people with autism have special interests; it can help to translate those interests into age-appropriate recreational activities.

Learn more in Autism Speaks [Autism and Recreation](#) and [Tips to create inclusive sports and recreation activities](#). You can also search the Autism Speaks [Resource Guide](#) for activities near you that may interest your loved one.

Be Positive

Whether your loved one will move on to postsecondary education, live in a group home or continue to live with you and your family, independent living skills will be important to their well-being. At times along the way, you may feel frustrated with their progress or lack thereof. But keep trying and little by little, they will learn some of these skills. Celebrate them wherever they are in that learning process. Celebrate yourself for encouraging them.

Health

Hygiene

Personal hygiene is an important life skill. Bathing, washing hair, using deodorant, brushing teeth and washing hands are all necessary to be healthy and for social well-being.

Teaching your loved one hygiene associated with private parts early can serve as a good bridge to sex education and help with the prevention of sexual abuse. More on that next under [Sexuality](#) and in the [Safety](#) section.

Most school curriculums will cover personal hygiene as part of a general education health or physical education class. If not, and your loved

one has an IEP, you can request hygiene be part of their goals. If they have a 504 plan, you can request hygiene accommodations, if your loved one has sensitivity around public bathrooms. For example, they can be allowed to use one restroom that is most comfortable and at a time of day that works for them.

At home, you should consider putting together a hygiene kit or shower caddy with all the essentials: shampoo, soap, wash cloth, deodorant, moisturizer, toothbrush, toothpaste, floss, mouthwash, etc. This way, everything will be in one spot and portable. For instance, if you go on vacation, you can simply pack it with you. When you run out of one thing, like shampoo, you can also easily look at everything else to see if you need to restock those, too.

Sensory sensitivities and personal hygiene products

Puberty can bring on new personal preferences and sensory sensitivities. That can present a challenge when it comes to picking out personal hygiene products and sticking with them. To help, here are a few strategies to consider:

1. You can still use whatever soaps and shampoos used during childhood. Many of those products are only packaged to be child-friendly. But they contain the same cleaning agents as those for adults. In fact, they may have less perfumes and dyes which can cause skin irritations. So there is no reason to switch if what you have works.
2. When it comes to deodorant, you are going to have to try and see what you like. There are so many different varieties from spray on, to roll on gels, to powders. A good place to start is with travel sizes. Most grocery stores and drugstores have these. You can also check out product websites to see if they have trial or sample sizes.
3. Face washes and acne creams can increase skin irritation. Talk to your pediatrician or see a dermatologist for recommendations. Most have samples for you to try.
4. Go easy on scented products. Many adult products smell nice, at first, in their container. But they smell differently on different people. Their smell can also change depending on what activity you are doing and over the course of a day. Strong smells can trigger sensory issues and even cause a headache.
5. Shaving is a known challenge for autistic people. Shaving products, too, can irritate skin. Trial and error and patience are key to getting shaving right. Just like with deodorants, there is a wide range of products, many now made for those with disabilities and with safety top-of-mind.

Learn more: [*For my teen with autism, shaving is a two-person job*](#)

Mental health

Most autistic people experience one or more co-occurring mental health conditions. Among the more common ones are anxiety and ADHD. Many of these present during or after adolescence. A delay in diagnosis can be complicated by the assumption that certain behaviors and emotions are connected to autism, not the mental health condition.

Learn more: *Autism Speaks* [Autism and Mental Health](#)

This is why it is important for people with autism to be seen by a pediatrician or primary care physician on an annual basis. Mental health screening should be a routine part of doctor visits, just like a weight check and blood pressure reading. But you should also be open with your doctor about any changes you experience or witness in behavior, mood or activity. You should also be open about seeking mental health help.

You can start by accessing guidance counseling available through school. You do not need an IEP or 504 to see a school counselor for mental health help. But if you have either, make sure it includes guidance goals. For instance, you can have weekly or twice monthly mental health check-ins.

You can plan for future mental health needs in your Healthcare Transition Plan, which you should start planning now, too, using our [Healthcare Transition Roadmap](#).

Learn more: [Healthcare Transition](#)

Puberty

The onset of puberty and the body's changes can be especially difficult for those with autism. Preparation is key. So it is essential you learn, or you teach your loved one in advance about these changes.

Most school curriculums will cover puberty as part of a general education health or physical education class. Caregivers should be notified in advance and in some cases be asked to give consent to the teaching. This is your time to ask questions about what is taught and how.

Regardless of how puberty is taught or by whom, you or your loved one should understand changes in the body and those that will come in the future. These changes are a natural part of the human body and should not be viewed as odd or scary.

Among the changes that should be covered are the growth of pubic hair, under arm hair, menstruation, erections and ejaculation. It is also important to understand these changes happen over time and at different times for everyone. These discussions may be uncomfortable. That is okay. No one is alone in experiencing these changes.

Sexuality

Many autistic teens are nervous about learning about sexuality and many of their caregivers are more nervous about teaching about it. But sex education is arguably more important for individuals with autism due to the increased presence of it online, in movies and in general in the media, and their mixed messaging about it.

Like with puberty, most school curriculums will cover sex education as part of a general education health or physical education class. Caregivers should be notified in advance and in some cases be asked to give consent to the teaching. Many school districts share the curriculum in advance with caregivers so they can preview and follow along as their loved one learns.

Dr. Shana Nichols, Ph.D., a specialist in autism and sexuality, suggests that a sexuality education curriculum include: the body, privacy, boundaries/touch, expressing affection, social skills and exploitation prevention. It is also important to stress the difference between public and private with regards to places, body parts, behaviors, etc.

Relationship skills should also be included, according to Dr. Nichols. During adolescence, there are new dynamics to learn and understand with different types of relationships. All relationships, including those with strangers, teachers, doctors, family members, etc. need to

be addressed very directly to understand what makes each of them healthy and appropriate. During sex education it is crucial for autistic teens to learn the difference between

appropriate and inappropriate behavior, and to be able to identify what a healthy relationship is.

Safety

Transitioning to adulthood introduces new environments and social situations and in turn, new safety considerations. It is important that you or your loved one learn the following safety basics.

Fire Safety

- The fire exit plan for the home
- To evacuate if they hear a fire alarm, even if they don't see or smell smoke
- How to call 911

Water Safety

- Basic swimming lessons
- How to identify lifeguards and when to go to them
- The rules of public swimming spaces
- The dangers of water

Calling 911

- When to call 911
- What to say to an emergency operator
- How to whisper into the phone if in danger
- Contact information (phone number) and location (address)

These should be taught at home and at school. Water safety can be handled at swim classes, community swimming pools and/or community centers like the YMCA. Our [Swim and Water Safety](#) and [Resource Guide](#) can help you locate swimming lessons.

Learn more: Autism Speaks [Autism Safety Kit](#)

Interacting with first responders

By some estimates, people with autism are seven times more likely to have interactions with first responders than their peers. To make sure these interactions are safe and effective, it is critical you or your loved one learns how to identify, where to find and how to contact first responders. Schools can provide opportunities for this if it is not part of standard education.

You may want to also create a personal identification card that you or your loved one can present to first responders in the event of an emergency. It should contain all important identifying information and an emergency

contact. It does not need to contain a diagnosis, but it could contain a simple line like, "I have trouble communicating and maintaining eye contact."

If your loved one is nonverbal and/or wanders, you may want to create a more formal informational packet and share it with first responders, school, neighbors and/or coworkers. This might contain information about your loved one's challenges, other medical conditions, the most effective ways to communicate with them, their favorite places and more.

Learn more: Autism Speaks [Autism Safety Kit](#)

Increasingly, local police departments are hosting meet-and-greets to introduce themselves to those with disabilities and vulnerable communities. Some even host practice traffic stop programs with autistic drivers. You may want to look into these opportunities.

Learn more: [Autism and driving: Ways to identify as autistic when driving](#)

Understanding consent

Consent means having autonomy over your body, or the right to set boundaries over who can touch you, when, and in what way. A boundary around physical touch may look like:

- I don't want to hug people I'm not close to (or I don't want to hug at all).
- I don't want anyone to touch my hair.
- I don't want to cuddle right now.

Learning how to say "no" is an important aspect of consent. Nobody is owed access to your body, even people you love or trust. It is always valid to say "no" to physical touch if you do not want it, and you can revoke access to touch at any time and for any reason. Likewise, you need to ask for consent before touching someone in any way and respect the boundaries they set.

If you are a caregiver, teaching your autistic loved one about consent and boundary setting is essential for safety and preventing abuse. For example, before they begin dating, which can start in early teen years, talk to them about what consent looks like in romantic relationships, how to set boundaries, and what to do if a romantic partner does not respect the boundaries they set. In addition to talking about consent, discuss the difference between public and private places. Tell them directly that if someone violates these boundaries, they can tell you and you will help them.

Preventing abuse

Research suggests that autistic individuals are more likely to be victims of abuse than their neurotypical peers. Abuse is commonly committed by people known to the individual (a family member, staffer, respite care provider, etc.). There is also concern that many abuse cases go unreported because the individual may not know whether an act is abusive, may not be able to communicate the abuse, may feel ashamed of what they have endured, or may be afraid of what will happen if they tell someone.

If you are a caregiver, you can help prevent abuse by:

Teaching your loved one that abuse comes in many forms including emotional, physical and sexual. Make sure they understand what inappropriate treatment by others may occur so they can identify potential danger.

Telling your loved one that you are a safe person to talk to and that you will never judge them for anything they say. Assure them that you are there to listen, believe and help. This will help keep communication lines open. It is important to say this directly because, even if your autistic loved one knows that you care, they may feel ashamed or scared and unsure how you will react.

Making sure that your loved one knows abuse is never their fault. This will help them report any suspicion or acts of abuse.

Continue talking regularly about consent and checking in so that, if anyone abuses your loved one in any way or makes them uncomfortable, they know they can tell you.

Learn more: [Recognizing and preventing abuse](#)

Signs of abuse in autistic people who are nonverbal or who struggle with expressing themselves through words may be subtle and even difficult to recognize.

Learn more: [Recognizing signs of abuse in profound autism](#)

Make sure you evaluate the relationships your child has with people in their life and be on

the lookout for warning signs. When teaching your child about boundaries, make sure you emphasize how there are different boundaries for different people. For example, your sister can hug you but an aide at your school should not. Or, Dr. Smith is allowed to see your private parts after they tell you why they need to during an exam and get your permission.

If you are an autistic young adult and you have experienced abuse, or if you have questions about whether an action is abusive, talk to someone you trust. This could be a friend, family member, therapist, teacher, doctor or any other adult in your support network. They can protect you from further abuse and get you the care you need to recover.
Abuse is never your fault.

You can also contact the following crisis lines where a trained volunteer will listen and help you:

[National Domestic Violence Hotline](#)

[Love is Respect](#)

[RAINN National Sexual Assault Hotline](#)

Technology

Digital Citizenship

Digital citizenship is the ability to engage in our digital environments in a way that's safe, responsible and respectful. It includes thinking critically about how you engage online, what digital media you consume and share, and how you use social media.

Every person should learn how to be a good digital citizen and how to make good choices when using technology. These are important skills in today's world that can open doors to new opportunities in school, work and

community life. Conversely, bad choices online can have lifelong negative consequences.

Common Sense Media's Digital Citizenship course is considered the gold star in teaching because it breaks down lessons by grade levels 9 to 12 (and even younger) and by topic. If your or your loved one's school does not offer this, it is recommended you check this out.

Subjects covered include: *Protecting Online Reputation, Hoaxes and Fakes, Social Media and How You Feel, Countering Hate Speech, Can Media Be Addictive, Who's Looking at Your Digital Footprint* and *The Health Effects of Screen Time*.

If you are a caregiver of a loved one who is a pre-teen or one with higher support needs, you may find the following courses more age- and ability-appropriate to review together:

[FBI Safe Online Surfing \(SOS\) Program](#)

[Khan Academy Internet Safety Course](#)

[Be Internet Awesome with Google](#)

Social media and online community safety

You or your autistic loved one may find it easier to socialize online. You can easily connect to people who share your interests, you don't have to worry about nonverbal cues, and you can do it all from a comfortable space. There is no worrying about complicated social rules and sensory overload. Social skills learned there can also serve as practice for school, work and in the community.

Learn more: [Social media offers benefits for autistic community](#)

That said, you have to be careful of how you interact, who you interact with and the digital footprint you leave behind. If you or your loved one cannot acknowledge or understand the following, then it may not yet be safe for you or them to engage with social media or online communities.

- Keep your information to yourself. Don't post your full name, Social Security number, address, phone number or bank or credit card account numbers – and don't post other people's either.
- Control who can see the information you post. You can limit access to your social media accounts to a select group of people like your family, friends from school or work, and those you met online who you verified as real and safe to connect with.
- Be cautious about posting information that could be used to identify you or locate you offline. This could include the name of your school, your house of worship, where you work or hang out.
- Make sure your screen name or account name doesn't say too much about you. Don't use your name, age or hometown.
- Post only information that you are comfortable with others seeing and knowing about you. Before you post, share or comment, ask yourself: would you want your parents, your teacher, the police, the college you want to apply to, or your boss to see it?
- Remember that once you post information online, you can't take it back. Even if you delete the information from a site, older versions exist on other people's devices. Additionally, someone you shared something with can screenshot it and share it with others.
- Be cautious about meeting a new online friend in person. If you do decide to meet the person, be smart about it: Meet in a public place, during the day, and consider bringing along someone you trust. Tell an adult or a responsible sibling or friend where you're going and when you expect to be back.
- Cyberbullying is a significant risk for autistic people. Trust your gut if you have suspicions that you are being bullied. If you feel threatened by someone or uncomfortable because of something online, you must tell an adult you trust. You may want to report it to the police and the site. Also, learn how to use punctuation, emojis, and capitalization to prevent any misunderstanding in how someone perceives your online activity.
- Establish screen time boundaries. Research has established a link between the use of social media and sleep problems –which is not good news considering autistic youth are already at increased risk for sleep problems. So it is important to set time limits and a cut-off time before bedtime.

Digital tools

Smartphones, tablets, laptops and other digital devices are useful tools for managing daily living. You or your loved one should consider some of these to help with daily living, time management and other executive functioning areas.

[Habitica](#) and [Finch](#) can help turn your schedule and to-do list into a game. Both help make accomplishing tasks fun instead of something stressful.

[Goblin Tools](#) is an AI tool designed specifically for neurodivergent people. It can help with breaking down projects into smaller steps, estimating the time to complete a task, understanding the tone of a message, decision-making skills and even finding a recipe based on ingredients you have.

[Neurotranslator](#) is another AI assistance tool that can help autistic young adults communicate with neurotypical people and understand possible intentions behind actions they don't understand.

Transportation

Everyone should learn how to walk across the street safely. That includes understanding intersections, street signs, traffic light signals, and looking both ways. This can easily be taught and practiced at home and school.

Travel training

Travel training should cover all modes of transportation including public buses, trains and subways, public services like paratransit, rideshares and driving. Travel training can be part of your or your loved one's IEP. For instance, driver's education is commonly included in IEPs. More on this next.

Your state Vocational Rehabilitation (VR) office can also help teach you or your loved one how to travel to/from work. Postsecondary programs often have a travel curriculum as well.

At home, you could practice using the public transportation in your area. Maybe you buy a ticket, locate your local bus stop, find its schedule, and take it to a local favorite spot.

You should also consider installing public transportation apps on your mobile devices. They often contain options to buy tickets, routes and delay notices.

Additionally, you should look into paratransit services offered in your area. The Americans with Disabilities Act (ADA) requires public transit agencies that provide fixed route service to provide "complementary paratransit" service to people with disabilities who cannot use the fixed route bus or rail service because of a disability.

Learn more: [State Directory: Transition to Adulthood](#)

You should also consider learning about rideshare services, mostly accessible through mobile apps. Make sure to look at their customer reviews and ratings to get an idea of their safety record and reliability. A great way to learn how rideshares work is to take a couple practice rides with a trusted friend or relative. This is especially helpful in learning how to identify which car is yours and confirming the details of your trip with your driver.

Learning to drive

Autistic people can and do drive. Your road to driving just might look different from others though. For example, you might decide to use an adaptive driving program for your individual needs while your non-autistic peers may do a group driving lesson. Or, you might wait until you are older to learn to drive. Still, you get your driver's license in the exact same manner as everyone else.

Of note, there are no legal restrictions that prevent you from obtaining a driver's license solely based on your diagnosis. In fact, there is no legal requirement for you to disclose your diagnosis ahead of learning to drive or taking your driving test. You just need to meet the

same requirements to obtain a driver's license in your state as people without autism.

Learning to drive can be part of your IEP if you have one. Your goals can be written to include the same accommodations you receive in your academic classes. Whether you have an IEP or not though, you should approach learning to drive the way you approach learning anything else; use the learning style that works best for you.

There is no time limit to getting your license. So take the time you need to feel safe and confident. Keep in mind that around half of all people need two or more attempts to pass their driving test. It's ok if you are among them. It just means you'll be a better prepared and safer driver.

Autism Speaks [Learning to Drive with Autism](#) is a free, online course that can help you prepare to drive. Written by autistic people for autistic people, it covers:

- the practical considerations ahead of learning how to drive
- the basics of driver's education
- the steps to get a driver's license
- some strategies for dealing with common driving issues for autistic people.

Learn more: [Driver's License Guide by State](#)

As a safety measure, some states offer drivers the option to identify as disabled, and even autistic, on their driver's license. For instance, some states offer the Blue Envelope Program which actually involves a blue envelope to hold all relevant information typically asked for during a traffic stop.

The purpose of these programs is to improve interactions between law enforcement and individuals with autism, or those with other

conditions that may impact communication, during traffic stops. It is a way for you to inform an officer that you may need additional accommodations or patience. Enrollment in these options is entirely voluntary and up to you.

Learn more: [Autism and driving: Ways to identify as autistic when driving](#)

Transition planning

Early transition planning allows time to identify areas of support and leads to better outcomes. Healthcare professionals recommend caregivers start around age 12. Some states require schools and caregivers to formally start transition planning for an IEP between ages 12 and 14. More on this next in [IEP transition planning](#).

Caregivers of those with moderate to high support needs may want to start planning even earlier. For instance, what support does your loved one have now that they will likely need in adulthood? What adult medical providers are available in your area who handle autistic adults? What living situation do you envision will work for your loved one? What activities in what environments are best for them? Answers to these can help you research state and local providers who could eventually support your loved one's needs.

It is important to note, state agencies typically have waitlists to even be evaluated for such services. So even looking into those and finding out how early you can put your loved one's name on the list is helpful. Your research can also help guide your IEP meetings.

Transition planning should cover:

- [Employment](#)
- [Postsecondary education](#)
- [Independent and community living](#)
- [Healthcare transition](#)

Click on any of the above to go directly to that topic if you're ready to start planning for it.

Keep in mind, transition planning is a process and will likely evolve over time, and even into adulthood. Flexibility is key. Along with that, it is important to remember that many autistic adolescents find discussing their future scary. Some even avoid it. Some caregivers feel the same way, too. This is normal. One tip to help with this is to schedule a specific day of the week and a specific time to discuss future plans. This helps provide structure, set a time limit and give everyone time to prepare for what they want to share or discuss.

Getting started

There are some fundamentals you should consider to effectively start your transition plan.

Person-centered planning

Person-centered planning is a process to learn about the choices and interests that make up someone's idea of a good life. That is, it is centered around your or your loved one's desires, preferences, strengths and goals. Importantly, consideration is also given to your family's cultural and ethnic heritage. It has a constructive focus, versus a focus on problems or treatments.

Person-centered planning tools

Some person-centered planning tools require a trained facilitator and may be offered in school or other therapeutic setting. Among the tools autistic individuals and families have told us they found helpful:

[Charting the LifeCourse](#), produced by Ohio Center for Autism and Low Incidence (OCALI), a global leader in autism evidence-based resources, provides a list of questions grouped into categories covering the key areas of an individual's life. It is designed to prompt conversations about what adult life might look like. These questions can be used in preparation for or to guide an IEP or other transition team meeting. There are also useful supplemental tools to it including a guide for autistic people and a visual-guided [Integrated Supports Star](#) tool that can help plan for future supports.

[Exploring Possibilities & Supports: An information gathering toolkit](#), from Rutgers University's The Boggs Center on Developmental Disabilities, offers a convenient way to communicate information about an autistic individual's likes and dislikes, relationships, routines, communication preferences, and more, to form the basis of any person-centered plan. This guide can be completed and provided to IEP team members and service providers.

[PATH](#), originally developed by Jack Pearpoint, John O'Brien and Marsha Forest and updated later with Lynda Kahn, starts with a description of the dream or vision for the individual's life. The planning tool then works backwards to identify steps, set short- and long-term goals, and build a community that will make that vision come to life.

[Circles of Friends or Circles of Support](#), developed by Judith Snow, looks at who is involved in an individual's life and the kind of relationships. The goal is to help identify potential sources of support and where they may need to strengthen relationships as they approach adulthood and beyond.

Assessments

Assessments are important to identify a student's strengths, preferences and needs. Without them, it is hard to set, monitor and achieve goals. Keep in mind, assessments are not "tests." There are no right or wrong answers. They are simply a way to gather information. They range from informal, like interviews, to formal, like aptitude, intelligence and other standardized tests.

Schools must conduct age-appropriate transition assessments for students with an IEP according to IDEA. While no legal definition of a 'transition assessment' exists, it is most commonly described as "an ongoing process of collecting data on the individual's needs, preferences, and interests as they relate to the demands of current and future working, educational, living, and personal and social environments." The point being: there is not one specific assessment a school must give. Instead, options should be discussed based on the individual.

If you or your loved one do not have an IEP, rest assured, you can still access them. Many are free to everyone. Your school can also help. In fact, many school districts across the country routinely administer various transition assessments for all high school students, as part of general education guidance counseling. If they don't, ask them.

Among popular ones available for free online for all to access:

The [Community-based Skills Assessment](#), developed for Autism Speaks through a contract with Virginia Commonwealth University's Rehabilitation Research and Training Center, can assess current skill levels and abilities beginning at age 12 and continuing into adulthood.

The federal government's National Secondary Transition Technical Assistance (NSTTAC) [Collaborative Assessment Guide for Transition Planning Services](#) includes a

Transition Planning Inventory, Revised Transition Rating Scales, Brigance Transition Skills Inventory, and Life Skills Inventory, among other useful assessments.

Find a list of assessment examples at OCALI. Additional career assessments are discussed in Employment.

High school diplomas and alternatives

Students with disabilities have multiple high school graduation options beyond the standard diploma. Your transition plan should take your option into consideration.

Some of the most common ones are listed below. But each state has different options and guidelines. So it is important you discuss your options with your school administrators. You can also learn more about what is available in our [State Directory: Transition to Adulthood](#).

- **High School Diploma:** This is the standard diploma awarded to students who passed the required courses and exams mandated by their state. It is the generally accepted standard for admission into two- and four-year colleges and most other postsecondary education programs.
- **General Education Development (GED) credential:** This is awarded to students who have passed the GED test which consists of four subject tests: language arts, math, social studies, and science. Many colleges and employers see the GED as equivalent to a high school diploma.
- **IEP/Local Diploma or Certificate of Completion:** This diploma is awarded to students who have reached the goals on their Individualized Education Programs. These are state-specific. Most postsecondary degree programs only accept it for admission when accompanied by other testing or certification.

Autistic perspective: My 10-year journey to achieving my transition goals

by Chloe Rothschild



I started transition planning at age 14, per the legal requirement in Ohio. As part of the Transition Plan portion of my IEP, I participated in an early childhood education class. My general IEP also included adapted physical education, a teacher of students for the visually impaired, large print books, tests taken in a separate area, preferential seating, copies of notes, and sensory breaks. At age 16, I qualified for services through my local County Boards of Developmental Disabilities (CBDD) office based on life skills. I was assigned a services and support specialist who attended my IEP meetings to help with my annual transition plan review.

By the middle of my senior year, my family and I and my IEP coordinator decided that I would continue to receive school-age services until age 22. As part of these services, after high school I enrolled in a district transition program that was vocational-focused. It included time in a classroom learning office tasks and participating in leisure activities with support, and time volunteering at a local community center. I initially volunteered in the preschool but I just didn't seem to like it.

My school district tried to accommodate my needs but it lacked resources. So my family and I began to look at other options. After about six months on a wait list, in April 2012, I switched to an autism charter school which I attended for the next 2.5 years. I worked on life skills, social skills, and employment skills. I got to volunteer at the local Autism Society doing office tasks. One of my classroom placements was in a "living classroom" that was a house next to the school where I could learn cooking, chores and other skills in a real-life setting.

In September 2014, as my 22nd birthday approached, I became nervous about my pending transition from school to the world. While I had not qualified for any funding through CBDD when I was a teenager, I had assumed that I would automatically be eligible for an individual service plan and funding as an adult. But my family, school and I found out less than a month before that this was not the case. We were never made aware that this was a possibility, so we never even knew we should ask about it in advance.

So I worked with the transition coordinator at my school to make a last-minute plan to have some kind of structure while my family and I advocated for funding and services. Still, on my last day of school, reality hit that my school van was not coming the next morning. I was not going to school like I had since I was four-and-a-half years old.

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This was hard and made me feel upset. I don't think this change is something you can ever be prepared enough for. This is why many people refer to aging out of school-age services as "falling off the cliff."

I started part-time volunteer work at a local autism organization with a college student who functioned as a job coach. My family paid for their services privately. I also had a remote, very-part-time job typing in calendar events for a local business, which I had started while at the autism charter school.

Two months later, in November 2014, my family and I were still advocating for my waiver so I could access supports and services. After I had a meltdown during a meeting with someone from CBDD, they agreed that I needed funding. Finally, two to three months later, my case was assigned to a service and support worker with CBDD.

In January of 2015, I was also given an individual budget through CBDD. I used my budget for home care services, which help with things such as working on grocery shopping, cooking, cleaning and other life skills. I also had one-on-one sessions with a behavior therapist who helped work on different coping skills.

Around this time, my parents and I decided to start the process of applying for a Medicaid waiver, including preparing my finances. Ohio has three different Medicaid waivers for those with intellectual and developmental disabilities: Level One Waiver, SELF Waiver and Individual Options (IO) Waiver. The amount of funding goes up with each one.

The state uses an assessment to determine if you have an "immediate need" for services within 30 days or a "current need" for services within the next 12 months, which puts you on a waitlist.

After my assessment, I initially received the Level One Waiver. This gave me more hours with the same provider that was being funded with my CBDD budget. I was glad to receive a waiver, but I knew that in order to achieve my goal of living by myself with supports, I would need more services than what the Level One Waiver offered. For example, I wanted to be able to stay at my house overnight without my parents, but I didn't have the direct support hours to do it.

So while I continued to receive my Level One Waiver, I asked for another assessment in hopes of getting my name on the wait list for the SELF Waiver. It proved to be a much bigger challenge than I expected. After the repeat assessment, I was told I would have to continue with the Level One Waiver. My family and I ended up appealing the decision with a lawyer who specializes in helping individuals with disabilities navigate the system. I attended multiple appeals and hearings, and I underwent five more assessments in a year and a half.

Finally, in 2020, the appeals court judge requested a new assessment because my needs had increased due to additional struggles I experienced during COVID. I collected so many letters from providers supporting my case and sent them to the hearing officer, the judge, and the assessor.

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At the end of October, I got notification that our hard work had paid off: I was being put on the wait list for the SELF Waiver. Two months later in December, I received it. With the SELF Waiver I had the opportunity to practice working on independent living skills more frequently so that I could move out on my own.

In January of 2023, I achieved my ultimate goal and moved into my own place – a condo with a roommate near my family. This would not have been possible without the SELF Waiver. Because I had enough staffing hours, I was able to make the transition slowly. Now I have in-home supports at least five days a week. I get direct support provider hours for help with things like cooking, cleaning, grocery shopping, community outings and social events. I get transportation services to and from my job at a school for students with autism and to get around the community. I have also gotten funding for sensory items such as my crash pad and for my iPad as a communication device. I also get in-home ABA therapy hours through my health insurance. This is because my insurance is willing to cover it, and Medicaid waivers are considered the payer of last resort.

In total, the process to get to where I am now has taken almost ten years since I left school-age services. Even now, I still have to advocate for services. I send emails to my service and support specialist asking to look into things like new equipment, issues with transportation vouchers and discussing issues or incidents that come up.

Even though my family and I always understood that I may need lifelong support, we had no idea what it would actually take to access those services. I wish I knew that navigating the adult system took so much time, energy and effort. I wish I knew that it was never something that could be done quickly or alone. I want to encourage others to advocate for what they need, even if it seems to be like pulling teeth and feels like it takes forever. Reach out to others who have already fought the battle and do not be afraid to reach out to the state level for guidance.

IEP transition planning

Requirements

By law, all students who have an Individualized Education Plan (IEP) must have a Transition Plan that:

- starts before the student turns 16, though some states have mandated that it begin at age 14 or freshman year of high school
- is individualized
- is based on the student's strengths, preferences, interests and needs

- includes opportunities to develop functional skills for education/training, employment and if appropriate, independent living

Learn more: *Autism Speaks* [IEP Transition Plan Checklist](#)

The Transition Plan then becomes part of your annual IEP Review meeting. It is important to take advantage of all transition planning opportunities while still in school since IDEA and related services end once a student graduates or ages out of the school system.

IEP transition plan meeting

The process and laws around setting up the meeting for and creating the IEP Transition Plan follow the same for your existing IEP. But here are some helpful tips:

What you need to know before the first meeting around transition planning:

- If you need a refresh on your rights during your annual IEP review, check out Autism Speaks [Guide to Individualized Education Programs \(IEP\)](#).
- You have a right to ask for a draft of your transition plan ahead of the meeting. Your IEP team will have begun one based on past reviews.
- Use our [State Directory: Transition to Adulthood](#) to explore the various offices/agencies that support people with disabilities and provide transition services.

Who should attend the meeting

Required to invite: The student, parents/caregivers, at least one special education teacher, one general education teacher, and a representative from the school district (often from special

education). Anyone else involved in the student's current IEP must also be invited (speech therapist, behavioral therapist, aide, etc.)

Allowed to attend: Anyone who has attended your IEP meetings in the past or may be involved in transition planning. This might include postsecondary education representatives, Vocational Rehabilitation (VR) professionals, local social service agencies, support coordinators and independent living staff. You also have the right to have a translator, therapeutic support professionals, an advocate and/or legal representation.

What should you bring?

- Current IEP
- Prior IEPs and meeting notes
- Latest child study team evaluation; these should happen every three years
- Latest report card and/or any progress or tracking reports
- Communication log with school
- Transition goals
- Assessments and/or relevant evaluations from service providers.

Important

Students of any age can benefit from and contribute to their IEP meeting, even if their participation is limited. We will cover more under Student Involvement below. But of note, in most states, students become their own decision-makers upon reaching the age of 18, regardless of their ability. By law, the student must grant permission for their parents/caregivers to participate in their IEP meeting. The IEP team will inform the student of this right and present them options to having a parent/guardian present.

If you feel that your child is not or will not be able to make legal decisions on their own behalf at age 18, you may want to consider pursuing guardianship or other options to support them in decision-making. We cover this further in [Important considerations in transition planning](#).

Student involvement

The IEP transition meeting is a perfect place for you or your loved one to practice self-advocacy skills. You should have a conversation before the meeting to discuss its purpose, who will attend, where it will be, what to expect (ex: typical procedures like signing an attendance sheet), and who will speak on what topics. You or your loved one should take the time you need to participate, ask questions and fully understand what is being discussed. If there are time constraints because of other participants, a follow-up meeting should be scheduled.

Visuals or written language prompts may be helpful for those with limited verbal ability or anxiety. Their involvement can take place on a sliding scale of responsibility. Initially and/or for students with higher support needs, familiarizing them with the purpose of an IEP and answering their questions may be enough.

Student participation may look like:

- The teacher brings the student to the IEP meeting, encouraging comfortable interactions with some or all of the team members. This introduction may be as short as a few minutes where the student just says “hello” and is told why the meeting is taking place, signs into the attendance sheet and then is given the option to stay or go back to class.
- The student prepares a statement about their strengths, difficulties and goals that they distribute or read aloud to the IEP team and have included in their Transition Plan.
- The student writes sections of the IEP for modification and approval at the meeting based on assessments or other data collected by the case manager and teachers.
- The student co-presents as an equal member of the IEP team.
- The student leads the IEP meeting with support from a teacher, parent or support professional.

During the meeting, parents/caregivers should ensure their loved one is respected and their presence valued. For instance, model appropriate behavior by addressing questions directly to them and giving them time to respond. Or, if your loved one is having trouble answering a question, prompt them with a visual or written note. After all, the meeting is for them and everyone in the room is there to support them.

Steps to creating an IEP Transition Plan

Keep in Mind

It can be overwhelming going into any IEP meeting, and especially a transition planning one where others will provide input into your or your loved one’s future. Important reminders:

- Just like past IEP meetings, this is a collaborative effort. Input from parents/caregivers, the student and the IEP team are equally required and considered. The case manager and other school representatives should not unilaterally decide anything but instead make recommendations.
- Everything is open to discussion. You can agree, disagree, question and request more information before making a decision about anything. That includes anything added to the general IEP, and then strengths, interests and measurable postsecondary goals in the transition plan portion of it.
- Nothing is finalized until the IEP is signed. You may review multiple versions of drafts before you settle on a finalized version that you will sign.
- Transition planning is not a one-time event. It is a multi-year process that can evolve over time. The transition plan will be reviewed every school year through graduation or aging out of school-based services.

The meeting will be most effective if you are prepared. Beforehand, be sure to review:

- person-centered planning
- assessments
- graduation options
- future goals

Specifically, be prepared to discuss the following goals which are required to be addressed in your meeting, even if it is to confirm they are not part of your adulthood goals:

- [Employment](#)
- [Postsecondary education](#)
- [Independent and community living](#)

Following, we have a chapter dedicated to planning for each of these. Included is a section titled, 'IEP Transition Planning' that provides tips and sample goals you can use for your IEP meetings. Feel free to click on any of the above to go directly to that topic if you're ready to start now.

Your IEP Transition Plan must, by law:

1. Describe the student's strengths and present levels of academic achievement and functional performance.
2. Develop measurable postsecondary goals based upon the student's strengths and challenges.
3. Develop corresponding IEP goals that will enable the student to meet their postsecondary goals.
4. Describe the transition services needed to help the student achieve their desired post-school goals.

Besides stating goals, the transition plan should include:

- A timeline for achieving goals
- The people or agencies responsible for helping the student achieve their goals

- Guidance on the post-graduation services and supports that may be available to the student and referrals to the offices/agencies responsible for them. Think: [HCBS Waivers](#), which will be covered later in more detail.

If you agree with the Transition Plan and all other updates to the IEP, sign it. All parties at the meeting and any other school staff involved with the student will then receive a copy. It will be immediately put into place.

If you disagree with the Transition Plan or broader IEP, do not sign it. Document your issues, try to reach an agreement through another meeting. If agreement is not possible, you can file for mediation, which may then turn into a due process proceeding. You should consider consulting a special education advocate or lawyer before filing for mediation, especially since the school district will have their own legal counsel working for them.

A Summary of Performance (SOP) is required under IDEA. This document summarizes the student's academic achievement and abilities and includes recommendations to help the student meet their postsecondary goals. It must be complete by the student's final year of high school, but a draft should be started during the transition planning process. Specific information that must be included in a student's SOP will vary by state. Use our [State Directory: Transition to Adulthood](#) to find out what is required in yours.

Employment

Meaningful employment is a possibility for autistic people, including those with higher support needs. The definition of “meaningful” employment and how to achieve it will differ between autistic people. First then, we need to review employment models.



Employment models

Autistic people can and do hold traditional jobs. That is, they compete with job seekers and employees without disabilities to perform work on a part-time or full-time basis, for a market-rate salary, paid on an hourly or on an annual basis. Some can do so with little to no support or accommodations, or without disclosing their diagnosis.

But U.S. labor statistics show that a majority of autistic adults face barriers to employment and high unemployment rates. The federal [Workforce Innovation and Opportunity Act \(WIOA\)](#) in part has a solution. It is designed to help both employers find skilled workers and Americans with disabilities gain employment, training, and support services to succeed in the labor market. WIOA makes the following types of employment possible:

Competitive Integrated Employment (CIE), or competitive employment is work performed by people with disabilities, either full-time or part-time, for pay at or above minimum wage and including benefits (comparable to employees without disabilities in similar roles), in an integrated setting with workers without disabilities. Individuals are entitled to accommodations. But generally, no other long-term support is provided (ex: a long-term job coach).

Supported Employment is employment in an integrated work setting in which an individual with a significant disability is working on a short-term basis toward CIE. It is individualized and customized, consistent with the individual’s unique strengths, abilities and interests. In supported employment, the individual receives ongoing support services on the job from a job coach or employment specialist which can be funded through state Developmental Disabilities or Vocational Rehabilitation agencies.

Customized Employment is a strategy within Supported Employment for those with significant disabilities that involves tailoring a job or developing a role based on the individual’s unique skills and the business needs of the employer. It is carried out through flexible strategies, such as job exploration by the individual and working with an employer to facilitate placement.

There are also alternative employment models suitable for autistic job seekers across the spectrum, including some proven stepping stones to traditional employment or CIE:

Self-Employment is when an individual works for themselves rather than an employer. The [Small Business Administration \(SBA\)](#) has targeted programs to assist individuals with disabilities start a business, finance a business (with access to targeted loans and grants), and understand tax implications.

Apprenticeships combine on-the-job training with classroom instruction to prepare an individual for a skilled occupation or trade. It is an opportunity to learn-while-you-earn from an experienced mentor. The U.S. Department of Labor's [Apprenticeship.gov](#) connects prospects to employers and education partners with opportunities, and offers support for those with disabilities.

Internships are paid or unpaid positions in an organization to gain work experience. Many postsecondary schools and even high schools assist students in finding internship opportunities. [Project SEARCH](#) offers a one-year, business-led Transition-to-Work internship for young people with significant support needs in their last year of high school or who have just completed high school. It involves a combination of classroom instruction, career exploration, and hands-on training through internships in various job roles within a host business. The goal of Project SEARCH is to equip participants with the skills to secure standard employment in a competitive job market.

Volunteer work is a common introduction to work for all, not just autistic people. It is a great way to do something personally rewarding, get involved in the community and learn basic job and social skills. One concern with volunteer work is that it may create the perception that autistic adults will work for free. It can also contribute to the perception that providing work opportunities for individuals with disabilities is a form of charity rather than a way to benefit a business. So it is important to make sure that

when you or your autistic loved one signs up to volunteer, it is not to do work for free that other community members are or would be paid to do.

Sheltered Employment/Workshops are often segregated facilities that primarily or exclusively employ people with disabilities to do limited types of jobs or tasks. They were introduced under Section 14(c) of the Fair Labor Standards Act (FLSA) – and sometimes referred to as 14(c)s – and intended to be temporary places of employment for workers to gain skills to move into non-sheltered work. But sheltered workshops tend to be long-term placements doing tasks that rarely resemble actual jobs in the community. They often pay subminimum wages, too. For this reason, critics deem them discriminatory and exploitative. Many states have or are taking initiatives to eliminate the option to pay subminimum wages to people with disabilities.

Career readiness

According to 40+ years of research at Virginia Commonwealth University's Autism Center for Education, all autistic adults can work when they have:

- Employment supports that meet their needs
- Work experience during high school
- Participated in activities designed to learn about their vocational strengths and interests
- Connected to adult services as early as possible

Next we'll review how all autistic students, including those without an IEP or 504, can access these.

Career assessments

Career assessments should be part of [Person-centered planning](#) and should start around age 12 and continue into high school. They may be done at home, be a standard part of guidance counseling in school and/or can be

done through Vocational Rehabilitation (VR) services. More on VR next. The goal of assessments is to help identify interests and careers related to the autistic young adult's interests.

The U.S. Department of Labor's Occupational Information Network, or [O*Net](#), is the nation's primary source of occupational information. It offers free career and skill assessments that have been proven vital in helping people find the training they need and jobs they want. Among the popular ones for middle and high school-aged students are:

[O*NET Interest Profiler](#) is a self-assessment career exploration tool that can help students discover the type of work activities and occupations that they would like and find exciting. Students identify and learn about broad interest areas most relevant to themselves. They can use their interest results to explore the world of work.

[O*Net Soft Skills Search](#) is designed to help students use their skill set to identify occupations for exploration. Students select from broad groups of skills to create their customized list of matching occupations.

Vocational Rehabilitation (VR)

Each state has a Vocational Rehabilitation agency (sometimes referred to as Voc Rehab or just VR) that provides employment services and supports to people with disabilities, including autism.

Find your VR agency in our [State Directory: Transition to Adulthood](#).

Depending on your state, you may be able to refer yourself or your loved one to VR for services. Or you may need a referral from school (a guidance counselor, special education teacher or administrator, or an IEP team member) or a service provider.

A referral does not guarantee services, though. There are specific eligibility requirements to qualify for many VR services. One exception is pre-employment transition services (Pre-ETS). More on that below. But generally, individuals need a physical or mental impairment that poses a substantial barrier to employment, and they must also be able to benefit from the program's services to achieve employment. Some states VR agencies have wait lists due to limited resources. They typically prioritize services for individuals with the most significant needs.

VR can provide vital support to high school students with disabilities during transition planning. VR counselors can work with students to assess their interests, skills, and limitations, often through assessments. Importantly, VR can connect a high school student with disabilities with a job coach, a trained professional who can assist the student in learning and performing job duties.

It is common for VR to develop an Individual Plan for Employment (IPE) to help students explore career paths, prepare for and find employment, and potentially continue their education. The IPE should be in conjunction with the IEP Transition Plan; it is crucial these are aligned to support a successful transition to employment.

VR is available to those with disabilities into adulthood. So it is a good idea to become familiar with your state agency. For instance, VR can help with job placement, assistive technology, transportation to/from a job and even self-employment development. You may not need those now, but you could in the future.

SPOTLIGHT: Pre-employment Transition Services (Pre-ETS)

Pre-ETS is a national program offered through VR that provides skills training to students with disabilities to successfully transition from high school to employment or postsecondary education. WIOA requires VR agencies to set aside at least 15% of their federal funds for Pre-ETS.

Though Pre-ETS is federally mandated, awareness and participation vary across states. Many students who could benefit from these services may not be receiving them due to inconsistency and confusion over eligibility and implementation.

To clarify, generally, students with a disability between ages 14 to 21 and enrolled in a secondary or postsecondary educational program are eligible for Pre-ETS if they meet one of the following:

- Are eligible for special education services under IDEA, or
- Receive 504 accommodations, or
- Have a medically documented disability

This means students with a documented autism diagnosis could receive Pre-ETS in high school even if they do not have an IEP or 504. They do not need to be eligible for or a client of other VR services.

Students and/or their caregivers can access Pre-ETS by contacting their local VR office or by referral from their school's special education or guidance office.

Five key areas of Pre-ETS

1. **Job Exploration** to help students identify their interests and strengths, explore different career options, and understand the job market. This includes vocational assessments.
2. **Work-Based Learning Experiences** to provide exposure to potential careers and work experience through job shadowing, internships, apprenticeships and volunteer work.
3. **Postsecondary Education Counseling** to help students explore education options including colleges, trade schools and vocational programs.
4. **Workplace Readiness Training** to learn resume writing, interview techniques, social skills and workplace etiquette.
5. **Self-Advocacy Instruction** to teach students their rights and how to request accommodations in school and work settings.

Social Security: Ticket to Work Program

Social Security's Ticket to Work Program supports career development for people ages 18 and older who receive Social Security disability benefits (SSI or SSDI) and want to work. This free and voluntary program helps people with disabilities achieve their employment goals and increase their financial independence by reducing their dependence on disability benefits.

Through the program, you work with a service provider to identify your employment goals, and supports and services you need to succeed. You and your provider will develop an agreement called an Individual Work Plan (IWP), an Individualized Plan for Employment (IPE) or an Individual Employment Plan, depending on the type of service provider you choose. This plan is drawn up similar to how a school IEP is developed. More can be found at [Ticket to Work](#).

IEP transition planning for employment

Use the Autism Speaks [IEP Transition Plan Checklist](#) to incorporate employment goals into your formal Transition Plan. Goals should be based on assessments, age-appropriate, and have a measurable outcome that must be achieved by a certain date.

Examples:

"By [date], [student] will create a list of contacts related to their desired career or job position, write an email to each to inform them of their interest in their field, and ask them for an informational interview or to be kept in mind for any internships."

"After graduation, [student] will work 15 hours a week at the [local bookstore] and be provided support through Vocational Rehabilitation."

"By [date], [student] will explore the Ticket to Work program by contacting the program's helpline or visiting their website, with assistance from [a designated school staff], and will report their findings to the IEP team"

During the meeting you should also discuss how the school or district can:

- Facilitate a connection to your local VR office. Discuss how VR will continue services after the student ages out of school.
- Facilitate a connection to local agencies that host annual career fairs and coordinate for the student to be able to attend and have information interviews with employers.
- Ensure that the student is spending an appropriate amount of time in instruction related to learning work-related skills or in job shadowing or similar work experiences.

Caregiver perspective: Building a resume in high school for my son with higher support needs

by Michelle Rubin, mother and founder of *Autism After 21*



I began building a resume for my son Scott, who was born with autism spectrum disorder, when he was in high school. I knew he was not college-bound. So I started preparing him for a future in employment. I chronicled everything from classes, sports, Special Olympics, awards, work training and even computer programs he knew to use. For families of autistic students still in high school, my advice is to start building a resume now by volunteering and becoming a part of clubs or organizations.

Based on our experience, I founded the non-profit Autism After 21 when Scott was 18 to provide education, mentorship, advocacy, employment and social opportunities to other young adults with autism spectrum disorder. Our signature program *SOAR – Summer Opportunity for Adult Readiness* – is a 12-day, residential, job-readiness program held on college campuses. Our curriculum focuses on pre-employment training, career exploration, self-advocacy training, independent living, financial management and social skills.

Scott's employment journey

Scott's first job was with a neighbor's business that focuses on reusable plastic tags used in retail. I asked him if there was anything in their process that Scott could possibly do. I went and visited the plant, and we found job tasks that were a fit. Scott now works there part-time.

In 2018, a friend who does marketing and PR for a local restaurant here in Florida, Rocco's Tacos, told me about the possibility of an opening for Scott. He took a resume that I helped him write, he presented it to the chef and manager at the interview and he got a job as a dishwasher.

But he is more than that. Scott has taken it upon himself to fill some tasks on his own after seeing a need, including taking out trash and restocking dishes for the chef and bartenders. Scott likes to be helpful. His ability to figure out what someone in the restaurant needs that he can do makes him proud and feel like he's part of the team, like when he can refill glasses for the bartender, dishes for the chef etc. The chef reports he will turn around and Scott will have emptied his trash without him even seeing Scott do it. He just does it without being asked.

continued...

Supports

My experience has been supports are needed in the beginning, especially finding the businesses who are willing to hire. We went to Vail for the summer and were able to find a restaurant that was willing to give Scott a chance even though they had never hired anyone with a disability before. He successfully worked there for seven weeks.

Resume writing for a young man of Scott's academic ability must be done with assistance from others. Job coaching in a new position can make or break the success and longevity, and also gives the employer some confidence. Employers can be hesitant to bring someone into the workplace when they have no experience with adults on the spectrum. Assuring them they have supports really helps. Training staff what to expect so natural supports can develop is vital.

The job interviews can be difficult. Scott's speech can be difficult to understand if you don't know him. So I facilitated his job interviews. He also had a job coach from a previous restaurant job prior to the one at Rocco's. He was able to transfer those skills to Rocco's without a job coach. He went in on his own, got trained and has been successful ever since. Besides typical onboarding paperwork, Scott had training for the automated dish system from another staff member. It helps that he maintains the same schedule every week.

Autism Speaks Workplace Inclusion Now™ (WIN)

[WIN](#) is a workforce development program designed to promote employment of autistic adults and to create inclusive workplaces in which not just autistic people, but all employees can thrive.

Training courses

In collaboration with [Virginia Commonwealth University Autism Center of Education](#), a national leader in developing knowledge and research-based practices to support individuals with autism spectrum disorder, we created the following free courses that would be useful in transition planning for employment:

[Navigating Your Differences in the Workplace](#)

teaches autistic people about their rights in employment and empowers them to self-advocate at work. The course covers disclosure, workplace accommodations, and how to manage sensory and executive function differences.

[Supporting Your Family Member in Employment: A course for parents and](#)

[caregivers](#) covers the path to CIE for those with moderate to high support needs. It explains the role of a job coach and how together you can support your loved one in finding and maintaining employment.

Employment Tool Kit

Autism Speaks [Employment Tool Kit](#) is designed for autistic job seekers and those who have employment aspirations. It provides tools for the entire employment process from career assessment to the first day on a job. Included are job exploration resources, resume building tips, interview advice, disclosure and accommodation requests and the legal rights afforded those with disabilities. There is also a Workbook to keep track of service providers, assessments, career options, and a contact list, plus a sample list of interview questions, resume and reference sheet, among other helpful activities.

Join our [Autism Employment Network](#) on LinkedIn to share your skills, connect with employers and build your network.

Postsecondary education

Increasingly, universities, community colleges, vocational schools and other higher learning institutions are offering autism-specific support programs and expanding their disability services. As a result, a growing number of autistic students across the spectrum are enrolling in postsecondary education.

[Think College](#) is a great place to start exploring options for those with intellectual disabilities. [College Autism Network](#) is another good resource for students across the spectrum. Both have information on academic programs, campus life, and eligibility criteria for programs that support students with developmental disabilities.

Postsecondary education options

Four-Year College

In response to the increase in autism prevalence and later diagnosis of autism, traditional four-year colleges and universities are providing support services for students with autism and/or with intellectual disabilities. Many have even developed specialized programs or certificates for them.

If you're considering a four-year program, it is important to check out any prospective school's Office of Disability Services (or similarly named office). Make sure to find out what accommodations they offer and what sort of documentation you will need to qualify for them.

You may want to consider four-year colleges that offer **cooperative education**. These programs alternate between a semester taking classes and one doing hand-on work in a field relevant to the degree you are pursuing. Cooperative education can be especially beneficial to students with autism, allowing them to develop both academic and work skills, including soft skills, at the same time.

After you have been accepted, some four-year colleges allow incoming students to take a **gap year**. This is a period between your high school graduation and freshman year of college where you can take time off to work, travel, complete an internship or prepare for your studies. If you are interested in completing a gap year, reach out to your college's admissions counseling team for more information.

Community College

Many community colleges have specialized programs for young adults with developmental disabilities. They put a greater emphasis on the needs and goals of each student than a four-year colleges and universities, where the primary goal is to earn a degree. Students can enroll in classes to learn necessary important life skills like money management and problem solving.

This is one of the biggest advantages of community college. The pace and programming allow autistic young adults to gradually ease into adulthood and utilize the two-years to further develop self-advocacy skills and find their interests. It is also affordable, which makes it very accessible.

Vocational/Technical/Trade Schools

Vocational, technical and trade schools provide hands-on learning in a variety of occupation-specific fields. There are some programs that provide training along with general education classes like language arts and math. Many also provide internships and mentorships.

Participating in vocational or technical classes during the last two years of high school can be a useful transition strategy. If this option interests you, you should work with your school district to find out about local programs.

Life Skills Programs

There are many Life Skills programs available for people with autism that offer services to help them live more independently. These programs cover a wide array of skills like money management, shopping and transportation, and employment training skills in work settings. The programs also teach social skills and provide services such as recreational and leisure activities that will help with community integration, an important part of adult life.

504 Plans in postsecondary education

IDEA and IEPs no longer apply after you or your loved one leave high school or school district-based services.

However, Section 504 and the Americans with Disabilities Act (ADA) apply to any school that receives federal funding. So regardless of whether or not you or your loved one had an IEP, a 504 plan or no services or supports in high school, you could qualify for postsecondary accommodations.

To apply for accommodations, students need to register with their postsecondary institution's disability services office. This requires a level of disclosure; you must identify yourself as having a disability. While you can share your 504 plan or IEP from high school, it will not guarantee you receive the same accommodations in college. Note that Section 504 does not require an institution to compose a written plan, but most places will do this.

Reasonable accommodations can include audio books, readers or note-takers, access to the instructor's notes, extended time for assignments and tests, and preferential seating.

Considerations in postsecondary education

Keep these important considerations in mind if your goal is to attend a postsecondary institution.

- To apply for or attend college, you will need to obtain a high school diploma or a General Education Diploma (GED). An IEP diploma will not be recognized by institutions of higher education.
- Make sure you take all required standardized tests required by college admissions. You will likely need to take a college entrance program, like the SAT or the ACT, if you are applying to a university or community college. If you currently have an IEP or 504 plan, you can ask for test-taking accommodations. Getting help from a tutor and taking practice tests can help you get ready for the test.
- Find out what evaluations or assessments are required by colleges you are interested in to qualify for accommodations under Section 504. Some may request a re-evaluation if your current evaluation is more than three to five years old.
- Discuss your postsecondary options with your local Division of Vocational Rehabilitation Services (DVRS). They may have funding available to help reduce your costs.
- Make a list of your most significant concerns about colleges or other postsecondary programs. Bring these to IEP meetings or school guidance counselors to have needs assessed and concerns met.
- Create a solid support system to help with college decision-making, the transition to postsecondary life and future decisions you may need to make as you progress through your program.

Autistic Perspective

Ellie Rosenthal-Strisik, founder of *College for All*



For as long as she can remember, Ellie Rosenthal-Strisik wanted to go to college.

“Academic learning has always been one of my strengths,” said the high school senior from suburban Maryland. “I’ve consistently viewed higher education as the natural next step.”

Diagnosed with ADHD at 12 and autism two years later, Ellie had an IEP and started transition planning for college in ninth grade. From the outset, she noticed a problem.

“I realized there were very few [college] resources tailored for neurodivergent students, and that the ones that existed weren’t widely promoted, centralized or easy to navigate,” she said.

So over two years, Ellie leaned into her self-advocacy skills and got to work. She researched and gathered all the college information she could, interviewed experts who could offer meaningful insights, and connected with directors of college support programs to learn what they do well.

The result of Ellie’s endeavor is [College For All](#), a website that provides tips and tools to support neurodivergent teens interested in postsecondary education. It includes a list of 50 programs from around the U.S. and growing, handpicked based on Ellie’s research, recommendations from professionals and publicly available information. Programs vary in type (four-year, two-year, etc), size and support models.

Additionally, Ellie not only explains accommodations in plain simple terms, but provides questions to help neurodivergent teens think about their needs while they are on college tours. Useful accommodation examples are provided based on what is readily available on college campuses. She also included a downloadable PDF guide that can be used to evaluate the support services that colleges provide for neurodivergent students.

Ellie’s advice to fellow aspiring postsecondary education students: “Most of the experts I’ve spoken with have told me the same thing: you have a voice, and it matters. Don’t be afraid to use it. Just as importantly, choose the path after high school that’s right for you, not the one you think you’re supposed to take.”

She said that could mean heading straight to a four-year college, starting at a two-year school, enrolling in a transition program, taking online classes, or even stepping back for a year or two before continuing your education.

“There is no one timeline for success; your path is your own,” she continued. “The most important thing is to honor your needs, your goals, and your pace, and trust that the right path for you is the best path you can take.”

Advice for caregivers supporting their loved one

Keep these tips in mind to support your loved one exploring postsecondary education:

1. **Prioritize the tour experience.** The only way to know if a school feels right is to visit. Let your loved one feel the experience, get a sense of the environment, see where students live, eat, study and relax. Look inside classrooms. Trust their reactions and gut feeling during the visit.
2. **Make lists.** In addition to a list of schools you want to consider, write down their admission requirements, disability services offered and pros/cons of each option.
3. **Budget.** Plan out all costs involved in applying, visiting and enrolling in each school.
4. **Look into financial aid.** Exhaust all resources to find financial aid, grants, scholarships and government programs. Loans should also be considered.
5. **Be flexible.** Your loved one may change their mind about their goals. Keep an open mind. Postsecondary education may not be a fit, may need to be delayed or may become a secondary priority. Encourage lifelong learning but not a degree; not everyone needs a degree to be successful in life.

IEP transition planning for postsecondary education

Use the Autism Speaks IEP Transition Plan Checklist to incorporate postsecondary education goals into your formal Transition Plan. Goals should be based on assessments, age-appropriate, and have a measurable outcome that must be achieved by a certain date. Goals can evolve though and should be updated annually. For instance, a high school freshman may know they want to go to college but they may not yet know what their major will be. By the time they are a junior, they may have a better idea.

Examples:

"After high school, [student] will attend [a vocational training program or a two-year college] to earn a certificate as a veterinary technician. [Student] will seek volunteer opportunities at a local animal shelter to build to increase chances of program acceptance and build employment skills."

"After high school, [student] will enroll in a four-year college to pursue general studies. By end of junior year, [student] will identify three to five schools to apply to and work to maintain passing grades to meet college admission standards."

"After high school, [student] will enroll in a four-year college to pursue a degree in chemistry. [Student] will identify three to five schools with chemistry programs that match their assessment level during junior year. They will work to maintain passing grades to meet college admissions. They will also plan to tour schools and speak to their admission counselors by beginning of senior year."

During the meeting you should also discuss:

- Which type of diploma [student] will receive (high school diploma, special education diploma, etc.)
- A schedule of classes per year to achieve the desired diploma.
- All graduation requirements and a timeline to achieve them to graduate on time.

Autistic perspectives: Tips for managing postsecondary education

Choosing which postsecondary education setting and school is right for you is important. What will life be like? To help you find out, we asked five autistic people in different settings and at different stages of their postsecondary education for tips and insight on everything from making friends and picking roommates, to study habits, adding/dropping classes and communicating with professors, and everything in between, based on their unique experiences.



Binh Nguyen, Graduate of UI REACH, a transition program for students ages 18-25 with intellectual, cognitive and learning disabilities

- Be able to read and write clear and high-quality emails.
- Be responsible with your time and studies. Create a schedule that you can stick to.
- Build a community with your peers and instructors to develop your networking and social skills.

"Some things that were meaningful to me at my time with UI REACH were the community involvement and having friendships with the teachers, as well as finding time to do the stuff that I liked to do. I would go to sporting events such as football and both women's and men's basketball games. I also would get involved in clubs or organizations like Student Council, Dance Marathon, Triathlon club, Hawkeye Fitness Club and other such things on campus!"

Heather Mangus, Recent high school graduate pursuing training in a trade

- One of the most important things you can do is identify your learning style (i.e., visual, auditory, kinesthetic).
- Understand you are not limited to the college path. College is not for everyone and that's okay!
- Don't let your nerves hold you back. You are capable of amazing things. You cannot live to the best of your abilities if you don't allow yourself to overcome your fears of the future.

"I've always been a very hands-on person, ever since I was a kid building bird houses at summer camp. With this knowledge, as I was going into my senior year of high school, I knew college wasn't for me. I joined a welding class my first semester of my senior year and was obsessed with the possibilities it held. One of the most meaningful parts of the class was how welcoming and helpful everyone was, considering I was a first-time student. Within my first week I immediately knew this was for me."

continued...

Edward R., 2021 graduate of a gap year program for students ages 17 to 21+ with learning differences; Current student at Pace University

- Reach out to the professor when you have questions relating to the assignment. Don't be afraid to talk to your supervisor or schedule a meeting with your advisor to help you schedule classes. Learn how to self-advocate for your needs calmly.
- Find methods to help yourself study and manage the time better. For example, I use the Pomodoro Technique, which is a system based on 25 minutes of focused work followed by a 5-minute break.
- Give your mind a break when feeling stressed out. Take time to hang out with your friends and have fun.
- Keep trying and practicing resilience. Self-regulation and self-reflection can help during this new journey.

"When I first came into college, I met other freshman students on campus and in class. During my first semester, I took Introduction to Communications and Spanish courses. As time went by, I made friends with a few of the students from each class. I was very nervous about sitting with them. However, I asked them and they said I could sit with them. I asked their names, and later on, I became familiar with them. Sometimes, I would sit with friends in the cafeteria, and talk about some fun topics with them."

Emme Goldhardt, Graduate of Colorado State University Pueblo

- Do not feel pressured to go to college. There are a variety of other options. While some professions require a degree, there are many that do not.
- If you really want to go to college but are hesitant, do not be afraid to ask questions, seek support, or request accommodations.
- If you start college and find that you are really struggling, do what you need to do to take care of yourself. Maybe that means dropping a class, asking for more support, taking fewer classes or even taking a semester off. Talk to people you trust to help you figure out what's going on and what you can do about it.

"I more or less fell through the cracks in public school because I was obedient and got good grades. I was not yet diagnosed with ASD, though I did have diagnoses of general anxiety disorder, obsessive compulsive disorder and (incorrectly) major depressive disorder. For this reason, I did receive some accommodations from the start of college. Over the seven years it took for me to earn a BS, I had to drop classes, switch majors twice and end more than one semester early due to health reasons (physical and mental). While I am proud of my degree and grateful for the support I had that made getting it possible, I wish I'd known that college wasn't the only option."

continued...

**Dr. Stephen Shore, Autistic professor of special education at Adelphi University;
Autism Speaks board member**

- Higher education is part of the adult world, and people tend to be more mature and willing to help. Don't be afraid to ask for help from professors, other students, a learning center or a disabilities office.
- In higher education, students are responsible for taking an active role in learning. The more effort you put into your studies, the more you will gain.
- Just like students have different learning styles, professors have different teaching styles. Try to be adaptable and engage with how the instructor is teaching by "converting" concepts into your preferred learning style. For example, you can use lecture notes or recordings to create visual cues or graphics.

"Sharing the dorm room with my friend from high school was a helpful part of transitioning into college. At first we did most things together, except for going to our classes... Gradually our interests began to take us separate ways, and we'd spend less time together. Towards the end of the year my friend and I decided to part ways as roommates. Yet we remained friends, and still did things together at university, and we remain friends to this day."

— excerpt from Dr. Shore's book, *College for Students with Disabilities: We Do Belong*

Independent and community living

Housing and residential supports

One of the most difficult parts of the transition process is finding the right residential option for your child's future. Choosing a physical home and the necessary support services can be complicated.

Where to begin

It is critical to be honest about your loved one's needs, abilities, strengths, challenges, etc. Some important questions to consider:

- Where would they thrive? Where would they be happiest? Where would they feel safest?
- What setting would best help them achieve an independent life that works for them and fits with their overall transition plan?
- What supports do they need and what housing options can provide those supports?
- What setting can help your loved one expand upon their strengths and abilities?
- What setting would not work for them?

Many of these questions can be answered through the person-centered planning process.

Learn more: [Person-Centered Planning](#)

Additionally, you should use your school district, and your IEP if you have one, for help with connections to state and local agencies.

Find your local housing authorities in our [State Directory: Transition to Adulthood](#).

You can also check with your school district's special education parent advisory group for tips and recommendations. Other families you know who have a family member with autism or other developmental disability are typically a great resource. If you don't know any personally, you can most likely find some families through support groups or local autism organizations.

Lastly, [A Place in the World](#) is a useful resource for those pursuing autism and disability-specific housing options. It provides common housing and support definitions, guidance on market segments, best practices, and persistent, pressing needs in housing to help you explore the housing marketplace.

Models: Residential support

There are many different community-based residential service options. Some of these options combine housing and support services, while others allow the housing and support services to be purchased and arranged separately.

As you read these descriptions, keep in mind that states may use different terms to describe similar models:

SUPPORTED LIVING offers services to individuals with disabilities who are able to live independently in a home or an apartment. The services, typically minimal in nature, are based on the individual's specific support needs and are provided by caregivers working under their direction.

SUPERVISED LIVING (semi-independent living) offers more direct and intensive structured supports available 24 hours a day, if needed. The individual may live in a house or apartment, either alone or with others. Functional life skills such as banking, shopping, cooking and going to doctor appointments can be taught or supported by staff.

GROUP HOME LIVING has been the traditional model for residential services for individuals with developmental disabilities. In a group home, several unrelated people (all of whom have a disability) live together with onsite staff who are present 24 hours a day, 7 days a week. Instruction focuses on independent living skills and community activities. The house is owned and operated by a provider agency that also employs and supervises the staff. Typically, group homes have eight or fewer residents.

GROUP LIVING/OWNERSHIP (CO-OP) is similar to group home living, except that the house is owned by a group of families or individuals who have formed a cooperative agreement. Caregivers hired by the cooperative, in some cases, by an agency contracted by the cooperative, provide support services.

TEACHING FAMILY MODEL/FOSTER HOME LIVING offers family-style living with support services available 24/7 by professional teaching parents, usually a married couple. The individual may be the only person with a disability living in the home or there may be others with or without disabilities.

AGRICULTURAL OR RANCHING COMMUNITIES provide residential supports and services for a number of individuals within the context of a working farm. These models generally combine residential living arrangements with agriculture science and community-based employment.

ASSISTED LIVING FACILITIES/ INTERMEDIATE CARE FACILITIES (ICF) provide assistance with personal care and activities of daily living such as bathing, grooming, dressing and more. In some states, ICF programs also provide medication assistance and/ or reminders. Each ICF is responsible for providing active treatment, consistent training and health support. Assisted living communities differ from nursing homes in that they don't offer complex medical services.

DEVELOPMENTAL CENTERS are large residential facilities clustered on a campus-like setting where residents have intensive needs related to their developmental disabilities. Most states no longer run large developmental centers and some states that do are looking to shift people to more community-based settings and will only place a person in a developmental center on an emergency basis.

SPOTLIGHT: Housing options across the country



29 Acres

29 Acres is a supported living community in Cross Roads, Texas. Their mission is to provide adults with autism and other neurodivergent conditions with community and a safe place to live where opportunity and happiness are the standard. Residents with low, medium and high support needs are welcome at 29 Acres. The housing, life skills, and vocational rehabilitation services they receive are tailored to their needs, desires and goals. **Learn more:** 29acres.org

First Place – Phoenix

First Place–Phoenix, the property of developer First Place AZ, offers 55 apartments along with a community life program and life skills training for autistic and neurodiverse residents in a consumer-controlled setting. Units offer the comforts of home in a smart-home environment—with special attention to sensory sensitivity, serving those with no support needs, drop-in support, low support and moderate support. **Learn more:** firstplaceaz.org/apartments

Project Beacon

Texas-based Project Beacon organization tailors its housing support services to individual needs, and they serve autistic adults with low, moderate, and high support needs. Programs offered at Project Beacon include residential housing, life skills lessons, social enrichment opportunities and vocational training programs. **Learn more:** projectbeacontx.org

THRIVE Red Bank

THRIVE Red Bank is a neuroinclusive apartment complex for adults with neurodivergent conditions in Red Bank, New Jersey. Slated to open mid-2027 it will feature 32 single occupancy, private apartments rentals. Conceived by Parents With A Plan, a nonprofit composed of parents, families, and legal and housing professionals, THRIVE is a mixed use, walkable, consumer-controlled setting and is private pay. The project features a first floor with a teaching kitchen, health and wellness space and staffed concierge desk. The apartment building will serve those with moderate, drop-in and low support needs. Supportive amenities will be offered in partnership with the Rutgers Center For Adult Autism Services. **Learn more:** parentswithaplan.org



continued...

Unumb Place

Unumb Place, located in Lexington, South Carolina, offers group homes best suited for those who need 24/7 care. 24/7 staff man six homes on the 10-acre property that also includes a community center with games (ping pong, shuffleboard, board games, etc.), a computer lab and exercise room. Because they are classified as a Community Training Home II licensed by the state, residents can use Medicaid waiver funding to pay for staff.

Learn more: unumbcenter.org/services/residential-services

Checklist: Considerations in housing and residential supports

Once you come up with a list of housing options, you need to start planning visits and gathering information. Below are some questions you want to ask when looking at a specific option or speaking to a housing agency:

- What type of housing models do you offer?
- How long have you been providing residential services?
- What type of training does your staff receive to work with an adult with autism?
- What level of support does the staff provide to the adults with autism?
- Is support available 24 hours a day?
- Can I speak with other families who are using your service?
- How do the residents spend their time during the day and on weekends?
- How close is the local community and how often do you access community resources?
- Who provides transportation during the week and on weekends?
- How close are hospitals?
- What is done in a medical and/or behavioral emergency?
- What is done to support medical and/or behavioral needs?
- What type of training do staff receive?

When researching residential placements, keep your loved one involved in the process as much as possible. They should contribute to the discussion in the best way they know how. This is likely one of the most important decisions you will make, so it is critical to make sure everyone is on the same page and that an outcome is reached that everyone can be happy about, especially your loved one.

(3) Most residential service providers that receive public support, including all providers that receive Medicaid, are regulated by state agencies. For Medicaid providers, the state agency conducts routine monitoring – often referred to as “survey and certification.” Before choosing any provider, ask to see their latest monitoring, survey or licensure reports conducted by the state. You can also contact the state regulatory agency to find out if any complaints of abuse and neglect have been filed against a provider or if the provider has violated any licensure or regulatory standard.

Funding options

It can be challenging and confusing to navigate the funding streams for housing. Below are options and programs for you to look into when finding the right housing fit for your child:

Self-Funded Housing

Self-funded housing is purchased by the family and/ or the individual using private money and/ or public dollars. The funds are secured and directed by your loved one and family, not an outside agency.

When exploring ways to pay for housing, you should consider all resources available to you and your child, including:

- Donations
- Income
- Grants
- Foundations
- Banks
- Community Development Financial Institutions (CDFI)
- Credit unions
- Private insurance
- Special Needs Trusts
- Individual Development Accounts (IDAs)
- Pooled trusts
- Tax credits

Individuals with autism and other disabilities are often eligible to participate in state and federal programs designed to provide funding to build and renovate houses. It is important to know that each program has distinct guidelines and that programs can often vary by state.

Most public funding for projects will be contingent on your loved one's ability to pay for rent/mortgage and a social-service plan that addresses health and safety.

Public Programs

There are many public programs that offer assistance to people with disabilities and others with low and limited income. Below are the programs most frequently used by people with disabilities.

HUD Section 811 provides interest-free capital advances to nonprofit sponsors to develop rental housing for low-income persons with disabilities. HUD Section 911 Housing Choice Vouchers (HCV) are dispersed directly by HUD to persons with disabilities to spend on the housing option of their choosing.

Low Income Housing Tax Credit (LIHTC) allows qualified for-profit and nonprofit developers to apply on a state-by-state basis for federal tax credits that they can sell to investors and use the proceeds as equity for the development of apartment complexes for persons below 60% of area median income.

Home Program provides formula grants and loans to state and local participating jurisdictions to expand housing opportunities for low- and moderate-income individuals and households.

Community Development Block Grants (CDBG) are grants to jurisdictions that can be used to support affordable housing through land acquisition and infrastructure development.

Fannie Mae Family Opportunity Mortgage is a conventional loan offered through private lenders that allows a parent or guardian to purchase a home for a dependent adult with a disability. Individuals can finance the home as a primary residence and not an investment property or a second home, even if they will not live in the home.

Federal Resources

The HUD programs above provide funding for families or groups of families to purchase or rent their own apartment, condominium, house, etc. for their family member with autism. It is important to note, however, that very often costs for the physical home and costs for the services provided within the home are kept separate.

You should discuss funding options with the state agency responsible for serving adults with developmental disabilities. Below is a list of some federal entitlements that can help with residential support costs and other services.

Medicaid Benefits in most states requires individuals who need residential support to be eligible for Medicaid, a program designed to pay for intensive services. Eligibility is income and asset based. Medicaid pays for a wide array of services for people with disabilities, including long-term services and supports. One Medicaid option is the [Intermediate Care Facilities](#) for individuals with Intellectual Disability (ICF/IID) Individuals. Those who qualify can receive funding for comprehensive and individualized health care, rehabilitation services, and day programs.

Home and Community-Based Services

Waivers (HCBS) can help people with autism and other disabilities use Medicaid funds more flexibly. Waiver services are an option available to states to provide integrated community-based long term care services and supports to qualified Medicaid recipients. These programs may provide a combination of both traditional medical services (dental services, skilled nursing services) and non-medical services (respite, case management, environmental modifications). Family members and friends may be providers of waiver services if they meet the specified provider qualifications. The exact type of residential support included in an HCBS waiver as well as who is eligible for the program varies within and across states. More on waivers under [Important considerations in transition planning](#).

Supplemental Security Income (SSI) is a federal program through the Social Security Administration that provides cash benefits

directly to recipients. In order to receive SSI, an individual must be disabled and have a limited income, including a maximum asset limit of \$2,000. In 40 states, individuals who qualify for SSI are automatically qualified for Medicaid. Learn more and determine if you qualify at ssa.gov/ssi.

USDA Single Family Housing Programs is a federal program through which families and individuals can buy, build or repair affordable homes in rural American communities. Eligibility for this program is based on state income requirements. You can learn more online at [USDA Rural Department](#).

Learn more: [U.S. Department of Housing and Urban Development \(HUD\)](#) and [State Directory: Transition to Adulthood](#)

Sign up now: Waitlists are long

Regardless of the funding mechanisms available, the most important thing when it comes to housing and residential supports is to plan ahead. Unfortunately, at this time there are many more people waiting for appropriate supported living settings than there are openings in these settings.

Although there are state-funded day services and/or vocational rehabilitation programs for young adults when they transition to adult life, many families are surprised to learn that there can be a waiting list of five, ten and even 15 years or more for residential services and supports that are funded with public dollars, specifically HCBS waivers.

It is important to understand and monitor the waiting list in your state and stay vigilant in pursuit of accurate information. Get on waiting lists as soon as possible.

Community living

Community living, or community engagement is a broad category and goes hand-in-hand with [Self-advocacy](#) and [Daily living skills](#).

For some, it means being able to plan a grocery list, getting to the grocery store, buying groceries and getting home and putting them away.

For others, it involves joining a special interest or hobby group, a house of worship, or even a recreational team. Engaging with the community allows autistic individuals to build connection with others and their surroundings, enhance their social and communication skills, increase independence and build confidence. It is known to lead to improved mental and physical health.

If you are looking for opportunities to meet people who share a very specific or uncommon interest, broaden your social circles in real life, or excel at a specific sport or other competitive event and want to be challenged, consider inclusive activities. Here, people with and without disabilities participate together. Some activities and programs are already designed to naturally support the needs of people with disabilities. (Think: esports.)

But if you are interested in an activity and unsure if you can participate as you are, you can reach out to the organizer to ask questions, give them a heads-up about your needs, and talk about accommodations. The more specific you are about what you need, the better others can help you. It is ok if you don't want to disclose your full diagnosis. But it is valuable to tell the organizer about your sensory needs, communication needs, or other parts of yourself that would help them know more about you.

Learn more: [Autism Speaks Autism and Recreation](#); [Tips to create inclusive sports and recreation activities](#)

If you are looking for adaptive activities, some of the best places to find them are:

- Public/private facilities like pools, parks, YMCAs and fitness clubs
- Community centers and libraries
- Community colleges programs at local universities
- Youth groups or religious community activities
- Special Olympics

Keep in mind, Title II of the American with Disabilities Act (ADA) prohibits discrimination against individuals with disabilities by any state or local government agency. Title III of the ADA specifically covers public accommodations, which includes businesses that serve the public, like restaurants, retail stores and fitness centers.

You can search the Autism Speaks [Resource Guide](#) for activities near you that may be of interest.

The digital world can also provide valuable opportunities for autistic people to build community. Specifically, engaging online can help with traditional barriers like lack of transportation and communication differences. But it is important to make sure you ensure [Digital citizenship](#) is part of home and school instruction.

IEP transition planning for independent and community living

Use the Autism Speaks [IEP Transition Plan Checklist](#) to incorporate independent living goals into your formal Transition Plan. While finding appropriate housing cannot be a goal, building skills to live in various housing options can be. Goals should be based on assessments, age-appropriate and have a measurable outcome that must be achieved by a certain date. Goals can evolve though and should be updated annually.

Examples include:

"After graduation, [student] will live in a supervised living apartment with a roommate near their part-time job. [Student] will be given specialized instruction that includes task analysis to teach the skills needed to share household responsibilities, respect privacy and pay bills on time."

"By the time [student] graduates, they will be able to use local public transportation to get to and from home and their local [shopping center/community center/public library]. They will learn to read [bus/train schedules], be able to independently pay to ride and navigate a round trip."

During the meeting you should also discuss how the district/school can facilitate:

- A connection to your state's Center for Independent Living (CIL) and/or local developmental disability office in order to find out about local adult services or community-based instruction.
- A connection to your state agency that oversees HCBS waivers.
- Access to a certified driving rehabilitation specialist through VR, if they want to learn how to drive.

Healthcare transition

If you or your child see a pediatrician for medical care, it is important to switch to a primary care physician (PCP) who cares for adults around the age of 18. A well-planned transition from pediatric to adult care leads to better medical care and an improved quality of life for autistic individuals.

We created a separate, complete guide, the [Healthcare Transition Roadmap](#), to cover this important topic. Below we summarize the key findings.

Timeline

Switching to adult care does not happen automatically at age 18, 21 or when a child is no longer covered by a parent's health insurance. Instead, it is a process. Doctors agree parents/caregivers should start planning for the transition between ages 12 to 14.

That being said, it is important to remember that every person is different. Below is a guideline; the exact dates may vary for you. That's ok. You may have just started the healthcare transition process at 17, 18, or even 20 years old. You can still work through the checklist.

Additionally, rest assured that all pediatric doctors are familiar with and sensitive to the healthcare transition process. A pediatrician will not stop caring for you or your loved one without ensuring they have a primary care physician. There is grace and wiggle room in this timeline. It could take many more years, which could provide a more comfortable transition, and could be staggered among doctors if multiple specialists are involved.

Prior to age 12-13

Make sure your pre-teen understands puberty. State guidelines for teaching puberty vary widely. So while you should find out what your school district teaches and when, you should be prepared to take the lead on this. The American Academy of Pediatrics *You-ology: A Puberty Guide for Everybody* is for pre-teens 9 to 13. It embraces an inclusive approach that normalizes puberty for all kids.

AGE 12-13

- Request an updated psychological assessment.
- Have a conversation with your loved one about their health. Be sure they understand their autism diagnosis, any co-occurring conditions they have, any medications they take and why and any allergies they have.
- Talk to your child about adult medical care and the need to plan for it.
- Start to research adult primary care providers; look for autism experience and expertise.

AGE 14

- For girls and those with female anatomy, consider scheduling the first gynecological visit. Most will not need a pelvic exam. Find out more in [Finding an autism-friendly OB-GYN](#) section of our [Healthcare Transition Roadmap](#).
- Assess your child's readiness for healthcare transition using the federal program [GotTransition's Transition Health Care Transition Quiz](#).
- Encourage your child to ask the pediatrician questions about their health
- Encourage your child to start having time alone with their doctor during their visit, if safe. Start small and gradually increase it over time.

AGE 15

- Consider what specialists you or your child will need for co-occurring conditions and research adult providers.
- Talk to your teen about what to do in case of a medical emergency. Again, make sure they can tell a first responder (EMT, ER nurse) what their diagnosis is, any medications they are on and any allergies they have.
- Identify supports needed during a doctor visit and start practicing them. For instance, if switching from a liquid form of medication to pill form is a goal, ask your pediatrician to help with that.

AGE 16

- Discuss the referral to adult specialists with current pediatric specialists.
- Explore providers for additional areas including dental and vision care.

- Explore having over-lapping annual appointments both with a primary care physician and your pediatrician.
- Assess your child's readiness for healthcare transition again using [GotTransition's Transition Health Care Transition Quiz](#).
- Practice or have your teen practice making a doctor's appointment.
- Review, modify and solidify the transition plan with the pediatrician.

AGE 17

- Schedule appointments with all pediatric specialists to ensure transfer of care.
- Explore overlapping or joint appointments with the adult and pediatric specialists.
- Ensure your child can identify their medical problems, medications and allergies without parent/caregiver support, or know how to access that information.
- Teach your teen to carry contact information for medical needs in their wallet or cell phone. Or set up a Medical ID on their smartphone.
- Make a copy of your teen's medical record file and share it with them.

AGE 18

- Have final appointments with pediatrician and pediatric specialists.
- Confirm adult providers have all relevant medical records.
- Confirm appointments with adult care specialists for any relevant co-occurring conditions.
- Review consent with your young adult. Independence and privacy are legal rights at age 18 unless caregivers have guardianship. The medical providers will now speak with the autistic young adult instead of the caregiver. The young adult can give the okay for caregivers to be at appointments and to have their medical information shared with caregivers.
- Consider scheduling a follow-up visit or phone call with providers to report how it went in order to prepare for a successful next appointment.

How to find a primary care physician

One of the best sources for finding an adult medical provider is your pediatrician. If they have a recommendation, ask them to make a call to the new doctor's office on your behalf or write you a referral script. Caregivers should also check with their own PCP to see if they will accept their autistic teen, or if they can make a recommendation.

If you are near any of the academic institutions and children's hospitals in the [Autism Care Network](#), you can check with them or their website for recommendations. Or you use **Autism Speaks** [Resource Guide](#) and search for 'Primary Care' providers near you.

Alternatively, you can check with your health insurance provider. Many have a searchable list of doctors covered by their plans on their website.

In our [Healthcare Transition Roadmap](#) you can find out what to expect at your first visit with a new PCP, how to locate a specialist, and how to prepare for a hospital visit.

Important considerations in transition planning

Age of majority

In most states, adolescents become their own decision-makers upon reaching the age of 18, regardless of their ability. Parents/caregivers no longer have the legal rights to which they were entitled throughout their child's youth. This includes accessing confidential school or health records, signing documents for them, deciding where or how they should live, or otherwise making decisions for them. More on that next.

Importantly, as part of transition planning, autistic young adults need to consider their civic duty and participate in the following.

Voting

Americans with disabilities, including autism, are entitled to vote – and should vote. The number of eligible disabled voters in the United States, including the [estimated](#) 100,000 people with autism who turn 18 every year and become eligible to vote, are enough to help determine local, state and national elections including who becomes President.

Voters with disabilities have the right to:

- Choose a voter registration option that works for you. Check out what is available to you in our [Voter registration guide by state](#).
- Vote in private, without help.
- Bring someone to help you vote.
- Have an accessible polling place with voting machines for voters with disabilities
- Ask for accessibility accommodations that make it easy for you to vote. [The Americans with Disabilities Act \(ADA\) checklist on polling place accessibility](#) has information about what you can ask for. Service animal support are allowed and protected by this law.

Learn more: *Autism Speaks* [Autism Votes](#)

Selective service

Federal law requires almost all male U.S. citizens and male immigrants who are 18 through 25 to register with the Selective Service System at age 18. It is the government agency that maintains a database of men potentially subject to military conscription (the draft) in the event of a national emergency.

There is no exemption from registration because of a man's mental or physical condition unless certain criteria are met.

The requirements for exemption are:

- If a man is placed in a hospital, nursing home, long-term care facility or mental institution on or before his 18th birthday, had no breaks of institutionalization of 30 days or longer, and remained institutionalized until his 26th birthday, he is not required to register.
- If he is confined to home, whether his own or someone else's (including group homes), on or before his 18th birthday and cannot leave the home without medical assistance (for example, by ambulance, or with the help of a nurse or EMT) and remained homebound until his 26th birthday, he is not required to register.

Proof of the individual's circumstances must be provided to Selective Service. A determination is then made as to whether or not the man qualifies for exemption from registration.

Failure to register with Selective Service is a violation of the Military Selective Service Act. Conviction for such a violation may result in imprisonment for up to five years and/or a fine of not more than \$250,000.

Legal considerations with age of majority

Before your child reaches the age of majority, we suggest that you consult with professionals: attorneys, financial planners and medical professionals. They can help determine if your autistic loved one will be able to make critical decisions about their future.

If you feel that at 18 they cannot or will not, you may want to consider pursuing one or more of the following options.

Guardianship

In the eyes of the law, even a person with a significant developmental, cognitive or mental health disability is legally permitted to make decisions on their own behalf at the age of majority. The only way parents can continue making decisions for their child is to become their legal guardian.

Guardianship is a court-ordered arrangement in which one person is given the legal authority to make decisions on behalf of another person whom the court has deemed to be "incapacitated". The guardian's decision-making authority extends to all areas specified by the court.

The decision to seek guardianship can be difficult. You need to protect your loved one with autism, but there may be some areas where they can make sound decisions.

Fortunately, legal guardianship is not an "all or nothing" proposition. It is possible to carve out some areas where your loved one can retain important decision-making rights and control of their own life. Guardianship should begin with an assessment of the different areas in which your loved one may need assistance.

To start, you can consider their ability to do the following independently:

MEDICAL MATTERS:

- Seek medical care when they are sick or injured
- Weigh the risks and benefits of a recommended medical procedure
- Understand the need for routine medical care
- Accurately describe their medical condition
- Follow medical advice

FINANCIAL MATTERS:

- Understand money basics, like how to count money and how to make change
- Safeguard their money so that it is not lost, stolen or misused
- Budget earnings to pay expenses

VOCATIONAL/ADULT SERVICES:

- Apply for services from the Department of Disability Services, Department of Mental Health or other agency that serves people with disabilities
- Access necessary services and supports such as job training, employment support or a day habitation program
- Negotiate with the agency overseeing their care to obtain the best possible services.

LIVING ARRANGEMENTS:

- Provide for their own physical care and well-being including food, clothing and shelter
- Live harmoniously in a group setting, respecting others' needs for quiet, privacy and cleanliness

LEGAL AND DECISION-MAKING:

- Understand the implications of signing documents
- Make sound decisions in important areas such as living arrangements, school and work

SELF-CARE AND SAFETY:

- Understand personal safety skills, such as staying out of dangerous areas, not talking to strangers and keeping doors locked.
- Know how to call for help in an emergency such as a fire or accident
- Have basic safety skills such as being careful around fires, stoves, candles, etc.

COMMUNICATION:

- Communicate effectively (verbally or by other means)
- Understand that they have choices and be able to express them.

While your autistic loved one may need help with any of the above, you should also consider whether or they could be assisted by any means short of guardianship. For example, sometimes a person who needs help to make medical decisions can appoint a health care agent to act on their behalf. A person who receives government benefits such as Supplemental Security Income (SSI) or Social Security Disability Insurance (SSDI) can have a representative payee manage them.

To obtain guardianship, an attorney is not legally required, but you may want to consider hiring one with expertise in this area. Each family is unique in that there are many significant choices and decisions to be made in the process and an attorney can help you with those. You can search for an attorney in your area by visiting the **Autism Speaks [Resource Guide](#)**.

Supported decision-making (SDM)

Supported decision-making is a process that equips adults with intellectual and developmental disabilities to make decisions about their lives with support from a team of people they choose. It is an alternative to guardianship.

Each individual chooses what they want support for, the kind of support that works best for them and the people they trust to support them. An agreement is then drawn up. It is important for individuals and families to understand how supported decision-making works as early as possible in a person's life.

SDM is not available in every state; though, even in states without specific laws, supported decision-making can still be utilized.

Learn more: [National Resource Center for Supported Decision-Making](#)

Power of attorney (POA)

With the Power of Attorney (POA), your child will need to appoint you as the authority to make decisions on their behalf under agreed-upon terms in the legal document. Unlike guardianship, courts are not involved in a POA and the arrangement is often simpler and easier to change. The autistic person maintains more control over decisions than with a guardianship arrangement and as a result, this option is more common among more independent individuals.

Conservatorship

Conservatorship is intended to provide protection and management for the property of adults who lack sufficient capacity to make or communicate significant responsible decisions regarding the management of their property. Conservatorship not only appoints an individual with the authority to make these decisions on behalf of the autistic person, but it also removes the autistic person's right and ability to make certain decisions and enter into agreements of their own.

A conservator has no authority to make personal decisions (medical, educational, etc.) for the person whose funds they are managing.

Conservatorships must be filed in the Probate Court of Superior Court, in the courthouse where the proposed individual resides based on zip code. Most courthouses use Judicial Counsel forms and local court-required forms. Conservatorship is a lifelong process. The conservator must comply with the court for the lifetime of the individual.

Home and community-based services (HCBS) waivers

HCBS waivers fund the majority of lifelong supports that people with autism and their families rely on throughout their life spans to live, remain safe and participate in their communities. They can help pay for standard medical services (dental services, skilled nursing services, etc.) and non-medical services (respite, case management, transportation, employment support, environmental modifications, etc.).

Some states include certain services related to housing, like home modifications or assistance with finding housing when someone is transitioning out of an institution. However, it is important to know that because waivers are designed to support independent community living, they do not cover rent or room and board for residential programs.

Family members and friends may be providers of waiver services if they meet the specified provider qualifications.

All states operate HCBS programs for people with developmental disabilities, but each state sets its own guidelines. Some states also have specific HCBS waivers for people with autism. Waiver programs are generally designed for those who would benefit from round-the-clock access to medical services, plus personal care services like help with dressing, bathing, and going to the bathroom.

States also choose the maximum number of people that will be served under the HCBS Waiver program.

It is important to note that the HCBS waiver program is deemed a privilege rather than a right. As such, there are a limited number of spots available. A person who is deemed eligible can spend several years on a waiting list before they receive care.

Learn what HCBS waivers are available to you in our [State Directory: Transition to Adulthood](#) and find out the process to get on any waiting list for them.

Social Security

The Social Security Administration (SSA) has two kinds of benefits for people with disabilities over the age of 18: Supplemental Security Income (SSI) and Social Security Disability Insurance/ Disabled Adult Child Benefits (SSDI).

For your autistic loved one to qualify for these programs, they must meet the Social Security Administration's definition of disabled: the inability to engage in any substantial gainful activity by reason of medically determinable physical or mental impairment which can be expected to result in death or has lasted or can be expected to last for a continuous period of not less than 12 months. (The amount used to measure substantial gainful activity varies by year.)

To be considered, you must submit your loved one's detailed medical records, along with a list of all current medications and doctors, hospitals, clinics and specialists that they have visited to the SSA. In addition, your loved one will need to go through an examination paid for by the SSA. The agency will review whether your loved one's disability is on a list of conditions that are considered "severe" and if the disability would prevent them from working for a year or more. This process can take several months.

Not every student who receives special education services may be considered disabled under the SSA definition. Even if your family is receiving SSI for your loved one when they are under the age of 18, they will need to go through a redetermination process to maintain their SSI benefits as an adult.

Social Security Income (SSI)

SSI is available to people whose disabilities prevent them from employment. To be eligible, your loved one must not exceed a federal amount of resources and must have a limited monthly income.

Once they reach age 18, your family's income and resources are not counted towards theirs, even if they continue to live at home. Their benefit amount is determined by a number of factors, including where they and what other income they may have.

Social Security Disability Insurance (SSDI)

SSDI provides income supplements to people who are restricted in their ability to be employed because of a disability. Unlike SSI, this benefit is available regardless of the individual's income and resources.

Anyone whose disability developed prior to age 22, and whose parent or guardian is either deceased or getting Social Security retirement or disability benefits, may qualify for a form of insurance called Disabled Adult Child Benefits.

Representative Payee

The SSA appoints an administrator called a representative-payee (rep-payee) for all beneficiaries who are incapable of managing their own SSI or SSDI benefits. If you are seeking to become the representative-payee for your loved one's benefits, you must file an application in person with the SSA. You can be established as a rep-payee without gaining guardianship over your child. If they do not have income or resources aside from the Social Security benefits, you may prefer to avoid guardianship appointment and pursue the simpler rep-payee process instead.

It is important that careful records be kept of your loved one's monthly income and that it be reported on time to the SSA. A copy of everything you send to the SSA should be kept.

ABLE accounts (Achieving A Better Life Experience Act of 2014)

The ABLE Act allows families the opportunity to set up tax-exempt 529A savings accounts, called ABLE Accounts, for disability-related expenses. This law amended the federal tax code and authorized the establishment of private tax-advantaged savings accounts that can help you save for long-term expenses without sacrificing eligibility for public benefits such as Medicaid and Supplemental Security Income (SSI).

ABLE accounts are modeled after the current 529 education savings plans that help families save for future college costs. Once an account is established for a beneficiary, account contributions will accumulate tax deferred, and any earnings will be tax-free at the federal level if the money is used for qualified expenses.

ABLEtoday.org provides a comprehensive overview of how ABLE works.

It is important to keep in mind that not every state has enacted a state ABLE law and individual states may regulate ABLE accounts differently. But individuals in all 50 states have the ability to open an account. Find what is available to you in our [State Directory: Transition to Adulthood](#).



Learn more: [30 & 10 - Milestone birthdays for my son and the ABLE Act](#)

Conclusion

Reach out

The Autism Speaks Autism Response Team (ART) can provide support you may need during the transition process.



[Contact us online](#)

Please use the form and select “Resources, information or support for myself or someone I know” to send a message directly to our team.

We also have dedicated **Spanish language** support that can be accessed by emailing ayuda@autismspeaks.org.

Learn more

To support you with your transition planning, we recommend the following free Autism Speaks online resources:

[IEP Transition Plan Checklist](#)

[Healthcare Transition Roadmap](#)

[Employment Tool Kit](#)

[Navigating Your Differences in the Workplace](#)

[Supporting Your Family Member in Employment: A course for parents and caregivers](#)

[Housing and Residential Supports Tool Kit](#)

[Self-Empowerment Roadmap](#)

You can also find a list of all the state resources related to transition in:

[State Directory: Transition to Adulthood](#)

Get involved



[Join our grassroots advocacy network](#) and become part of a community of advocates who raise awareness for autism policy issues, communicate with elected officials, contribute to local events, engage other volunteers, and support positive change. Learn other ways to get involved at autismspeaks.org.